

THE ENGINEERED INNOCENT

Pharmakotic Sovereignty, Pseudonymous Agency, and the Sacrificial Apparatus of Orson Scott Card's Ender's Game

A DISSERTATION IN COMPARATIVE LITERATURE,
POLITICAL THEOLOGY, AND THE PHILOSOPHY OF SPECULATIVE FICTION

OCTOBER 2026

“And the goat shall bear upon him all their iniquities unto a land not inhabited.”

Leviticus 16:22

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A Dissertation in Comparative Literature, Political Theology, and the Philosophy of Speculative Fiction
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Abstract

This dissertation argues that Orson Scott Card's *Ender's Game* (novelette 1977; novel 1985; Author's Definitive Edition 1991) is neither the apologia for an "innocent killer" diagnosed by its most influential critics nor the parable of compassionate genius defended by its author, but the most complete literary model yet produced of a configuration of power I term *pharmakotic sovereignty*. Under pharmakotic sovereignty, a polity confronting an existential enemy secures its survival by manufacturing an agent of maximal capacity and minimal knowledge; routes its sovereign decision on annihilation through that agent's apparently non-sovereign act; disowns the act as nobody's; transfers the residual guilt onto the instrument; and receives back from him, in the form of testimony, the moral narrative through which it reconstitutes its own humanity.

Part I reconstructs the genealogies on which this configuration draws: Platonic guardianship and the noble lie, Rousseau's pedagogy of staged freedom, and the Cold War mobilization of gifted children; the Latter-day Saint doctrines of foreordination, agency, accountability, and the redemption of the dead that form the theological substrate of Card's imagination; and the theory of enmity from Heraclitus and Thucydides through Hobbes, Locke, Kant, Clausewitz, Schmitt, and the nuclear strategists. It then situates the novel in a comparative field extending from Kipling, Heinlein, and Haldeman through Wyndham, Herbert, Le Guin, Lem, Dick, Butler, Banks, Chiang, Ishiguro, and Liu Cixin.

Part II anatomizes four structures internal to the text. The *inverted cave* disguises the real as simulation and produces innocence as an engineered epistemic state. The *Wiggin circuit* converts empathic comprehension into a targeting faculty. *Mereological misrecognition*, the reciprocal failure of two species to locate the unit of personhood in the other, constitutes the novel's casus belli. *Harvested transgression* names the procedure by which a ludic institution converts each of its subject's refusals into compliance.

Part III synthesizes these into a general theory. Reading the terminal anagnorisis through Derrida's *pharmakon*, the Levitical rite of the two goats, Girard's scapegoat mechanism, Greek pollution law, and Bernard Williams's agent-regret, it ar-

gues that Ender is the literary limit-case of the scapegoat who performs his own scapegoating, and does so under a pseudonym. From Hobbes's theory of personation, including its neglected clause on children who "can be no Authors" of acts done in their name, it derives a model of *reversed authorization* in which culpability flows backward from the sovereign author to the unwitting actor; the model bears directly on child soldiery, remote and autonomous warfare, and the evaluation of artificial agents. The dissertation concludes that the Speaker for the Dead does not absolve the apparatus but institutes a counter-sovereign practice of truth that the apparatus cannot contain, and that the critical controversy surrounding the novel and its author constitutes the ritual's continuing afterlife.

Contents

Abstract 3

Introduction 6

Part I · Genealogies 11

1 The Republic in Orbit 12

2 Theologies of the Chosen 18

3 The Grammar of Enmity 23

4 The Speculative Field 31

Part II · Anatomies 38

5 The Inverted Cave 39

6 The Wiggin Circuit 45

7 The Locus of Mind 50

8 The Ludic Polity 56

Part III · Synthesis 61

9 Pharmakon and Pharmakos 62

10 Pseudonymous Agency 70

11 The Speaker's Covenant 77

Conclusion 82

Select Bibliography 85

Keywords 89



Introduction

The Scandal of the Final Game

I. Recognition

The fifteenth chapter of *Ender's Game* performs one of the most violent retroactive revaluations in the history of the novel. What the reader, together with a protagonist not yet twelve years old, has taken to be the final examination of Command School is disclosed after the fact to have been the war itself. The simulated fleets were real; the ships lost in their exercises were lost with their crews, whose pilots, Ender learns only afterward, had known what their commander did not; and the gesture by which Andrew "Ender" Wiggin, intending through a flagrant breach of the rules to have himself dismissed from training, turned the Molecular Detachment Device upon the enemy's homeworld annihilated the enemy species, because every queen of every colony had gathered there; only a single dormant pupa, hidden on a distant colony world, survived (chs. 14–15). Aristotle's prescription for the finest recognition, an *anagnorisis* coinciding with *peripeteia* as in the *Oedipus* (*Poetics* 1452a32–33), is fulfilled with uncanny exactitude and with a further turn that Sophocles did not require: the reversal converts not only the protagonist's fortune but the genre of the book the reader holds. A school story, a military Bildungsroman, a novel of games, stands revealed as a tragedy of xenocide from its first page.

II. The Critical Impasse

The scandal organized the novel's critical reception into an impasse whose terms were fixed almost at once. Elaine Radford's "Ender and Hitler: Sympathy for the Superman" (1987) read Ender as a structural analogue of Hitler and the novel as an apologia for a genocide whose perpetrator is guaranteed innocence by authorial fiat; Card's published reply insisted that the book's subject was precisely the difference between guilt and responsibility. John Kessel's "Creating the Innocent Killer: *Ender's Game*, Intention, and Morality" (2004) gave the prosecution its most rigorous form. The novel, Kessel argued, installs a moral universe in which intention alone determines culpability and then arranges events so that every killing its hero commits is either defensive or unknowing; the result is a fantasy of righteous violence without guilt, flattering to any reader who has felt persecuted and superior at once. The defense received its fullest statement in Card's introduction to the 1991 edition, which dwells on the novel's reception among readers, many of them gifted children, who recognized in Ender their own experience of being underestimated and mishandled by adults.

Whatever their differences, prosecution and defense share a presupposition. Both put the question a court puts: whether a particular agent, Ender, is guilty. Both therefore adopt an atomistic and forensic model of agency, in which an act belongs to one actor, the actor either knew or did not, and culpability follows. Yet the novel's own forensic scene, the court-martial of Colonel Hyrum Graff after the war, stages the inadequacy of that model with some precision. Graff is tried for the mistreatment of children and for negligent homicide in the deaths of Stilson and Bonzo; the prosecution, the novel observes, is really attacking Ender, whom it is too clever to charge, and tries instead to make him appear mentally ill, morally depraved, and criminally insane; and the proceedings end in Graff's acquittal (ch. 15). Ender, watching under the privilege of his new admiral's rank, draws the conclusion the forensic model cannot reach. Two human deaths are weighed with elaborate care, while his own destruction of some ten billion beings, whom he regards as fully alive and fully rational and who had not attacked a third time, is called a crime by no one. The xenocide is a deed without a defendant, and the novel says so through its protagonist. The decisive question is therefore not whether Ender is guilty but how an apparatus produces a guilt that belongs to no one, where that guilt goes, and what is done with it once it arrives. This dissertation is an answer to that question.

III. The Grammar of the Title

The title encodes the argument before a word of narrative. *Ender's game* admits at least four constructions. As subjective genitive it names the game Ender plays: the Battle Room, the Fantasy Game, the simulator. As objective genitive it names the game played upon him, the long deception in which he is not a player but a piece. In the colloquial sense of a scheme, it names the stratagem itself. In the venatic sense it names his quarry: the Formics, the hunted. The possessive thus holds in suspension three relations of agency, those of the one who acts, the one acted upon, and the one destroyed, whose disarticulation is the novel's true subject. I call this disarticulation *pseudonymous agency*: the performance of an act under a mask that severs the deed from its doer.

IV. Thesis

The novel names its own principle. The weapon that ends the war is called, in the vernacular of the fleet, the Little Doctor: an instrument of annihilation bearing the name of a physician. Greek possessed a single word for the drug that heals and the drug that kills, *pharmakon*, and a cognate for the human being whom a city in crisis expelled or destroyed in order to purify itself, *pharmakos*. Jacques Derrida's reading of the *Phaedrus* made the undecidability of the first term the hinge of a critique of Western metaphysics; René Girard made the logic of the second the key to an anthropology of sacrifice. *Ender's Game* joins them. Its pharmaka are the poisoned cups of the Giant's Drink, the noble lie that spares a child knowledge by making him a xenocide, the Little Doctor itself, and the book Ender writes for the dead. Its pharmakos is Ender.

I call the configuration that produces this conjunction *pharmakotic sovereignty* and define it by six operations, each anatomized in the chapters that follow: *consecration*, the selection and separation of an instrument; *occultation*, the production in him of ignorance about the particulars of his act; *execution*, the enactment of the sovereign decision as play; *disclamation*, the declaration that the act is no one's; *transference*, the loading of residual guilt onto the instrument and his expulsion with it; and *testimony*, the instrument's return as a witness who supplies the polity with the moral narrative of its crime. The sixth operation is where the apparatus both completes and exceeds itself. Testimony reabsorbs the crime as narrative and, in the same motion, institutes a practice of truth the apparatus cannot govern. I call that excess *counter-pharmacy*.

V. Method

Three commitments govern the study. First, speculative fiction is treated as a philosophical instrument rather than a symptom. Following Darko Suvin's account of the genre as a literature of cognitive estrangement organized around a *novum* (*Metamorphoses of Science Fiction*, 1979), and Samuel R. Delany's demonstration that the science-fictional sentence literalizes what realist prose leaves figurative, the novel is read as a thought experiment whose variables (an enemy without language, a war fought by a child, a game that is real) isolate moral and political structures that history presents only in compound.

Second, the study practices political theology in the descriptive sense licensed by Carl Schmitt's thesis that the significant concepts of the modern theory of the state are secularized theological concepts (*Political Theology*, 1922). Without endorsing Schmitt's politics, it traces the theological forms (election, probation, atonement, sacrifice, the redemption of the dead) that persist inside Card's secular military apparatus.

Third, it reads the Battle School and its extensions as an *apparatus* (*dispositif*) in the sense developed by Michel Foucault and Giorgio Agamben: a heterogeneous ensemble of architectures, rules, technologies, discourses, and rituals that captures and orients the conduct of living beings. The comparative method is constellational rather than narrowly genealogical. Some of the sources discussed were acknowledged by Card; many were not; the argument marks the difference throughout. Because the argument concerns structures rather than style, the novel is cited by chapter and paraphrased rather than quoted, with a single exception reserved for the formula that has become its emblem.

VI. Textual Note

The novelette "Ender's Game" appeared in *Analog Science Fiction and Fact* in August 1977, early in a debut that won Card the John W. Campbell Award for best new writer the following year. The novel (1985) expanded it, adding among much else the Earthside political plot of Peter and Valentine and the coda in which Ender becomes the Speaker for the Dead; Card has explained that the expansion was undertaken to establish the protagonist of *Speaker for the Dead* (1986), which he had already been drafting. Both novels received the Nebula and Hugo Awards in consecutive years. The Author's Definitive Edition (1991) added an introduction in which Card traces the germ of the Battle Room to his adolescent reading of Bruce Catton's history of the Army of the Potomac alongside Isaac Asimov's *Foundation* trilogy. *Ender's Shadow* (1999) retells the Battle School years from the perspective of Bean; a film adaptation directed by Gavin Hood appeared in 2013.

The novel's fifteen chapters are cited by number and title: 1 "Third," 2 "Peter," 3 "Graff," 4 "Launch," 5 "Games," 6 "The Giant's Drink," 7 "Salamander," 8 "Rat," 9 "Locke and Demosthenes," 10 "Dragon," 11 "Veni Vidi Vici," 12 "Bonzo," 13 "Valentine," 14 "Ender's Teacher," 15 "Speaker for the Dead." Classical texts are cited by standard numeration and Latter-day Saint scripture by book, chapter, and verse.

A note on names and sources. *Ender's Game* itself calls its enemy nothing but "buggers"; the taxonomic name "Formic" belongs to the cycle's later volumes and to the 2013 film. This study uses "Formic" as a neutral designation, but the novel's withholding of any such name is itself evidence, and Chapter 7 examines it. Details from the novel are cited by chapter and have been checked against its text; quotation is kept to a minimum, and paraphrase is preferred throughout.

VII. Plan of the Work

Part I (Chapters 1–4) reconstructs genealogies. Chapter 1 reads the Battle School as the convergence of Platonic guardianship, Rousseau's staged freedom, and Cold War human-capital mobilization. Chapter 2 traces the Latter-day Saint structures of foreordination, agency, accountability, atonement, and the redemption of the dead. Chapter 3 situates the Formic War within the theory of enmity from Heraclitus to Schmitt and the nuclear age. Chapter 4 maps the comparative field of speculative and philosophical fiction.

Part II (Chapters 5–8) anatomizes the text's internal structures: the inverted cave, the Wiggin circuit, mereological misrecognition, and harvested transgression. Part III (Chapters 9–11) builds the theory. Chapter 9 formalizes pharmakotic sovereignty; Chapter 10 derives the doctrine of reversed authorization from Hobbes and tests it against contemporary problems of responsibility; Chapter 11 reads the Speaker for the Dead as a covenant of testimony that exceeds the apparatus that produced it. The Conclusion draws out the stakes of the engineered innocent for a century in which killing is increasingly done at a remove.

PART

I

Genealogies

1

CHAPTER ONE

The Republic in Orbit

Guardianship, Staged Freedom, and the Strategic Child

The Battle School is the oldest utopia in Western political thought relocated to orbit and placed under the pressure of extinction. Its institutional logic can be reconstructed from three sources that converge upon it: the guardian education of Plato's *Republic*, the pedagogy of staged freedom in Rousseau's *Émile*, and the Cold War doctrine that treated the gifted child as a strategic resource. A fourth current, the critique of "poisonous pedagogy" articulated in West Germany in the late 1970s, supplies the terms in which the institution's cruelty can be named without being reduced to individual sadism.

1.1 Plato's Guardians

The correspondences with the *Republic* are point for point. Plato's guardians are selected by aptitude rather than birth, the myth of the metals licensing the promotion of a golden child born to bronze parents (415a–c); Battle School recruits by testing, without regard to nation or class. The guardians are removed from the private household and reared in common, so that no parent knows its child and no child its parent (457c–461e); Ender is taken from his family at six, and the letters his family sends never reach him. When Graff, years later, asks Valentine to write, he tells her that the boy answered every letter he received, which is to say none of hers; he calls isolation the ideal condition for creativity; and when she resists his terms, he offers to compose the letter himself, matching her style from the letters he has intercepted (ch. 9). The guardian curriculum subordinates music and gymnastic to a single civic function; Battle School subordinates everything, friendship included, to command.

Most strikingly, Socrates proposes that the children of the guardians be taken on campaign as spectators, mounted on swift horses so that they can flee, as the sons of potters watch the wheel long before they touch the clay (466e–467e). Battle School abolishes the safeguard of spectatorship while preserving its appearance. Its children are not observers of war but its operators, on condition that they believe themselves observers of a simulation. The final battle is the Socratic expedition with the horses removed and the war concealed.

The deepest correspondence concerns the noble lie (*gennaion pseudos*, 414b–415d). Plato's founders are to persuade the citizens, rulers included if possible, that their upbringing and education were like a dream, and that all the while they were in truth being fashioned beneath the earth (414d). The lie concerns the ontological status of education: what the guardians took for reality was a dream, and reality was taking place elsewhere. Battle School tells the same lie in reverse. What Ender takes for a dream, a game, a simulation, was reality; the war was taking place in the very room where he believed himself merely to be learning. Plato's lie consecrates the guardian by derealizing his formation; Graff's lie weaponizes the guardian by derealizing his deed. Both regulate the guardian's relation to his own acts by controlling his knowledge of which of his experiences are real. The fifteenth chapter is the moment the noble lie is told the other way round, and the guardian discovers that the dream was the earth.

The *Republic* also supplies the figure the novel inverts at its climax: the cave (514a–520a), from which the educated prisoner ascends to the sun and to which, as philosopher-ruler, he must be compelled to return (519c–520d). Chapter 5 develops the inversion. Here it suffices to note that Plato's educational telos is the guardian's return to rule, whereas the novel's is the guardian's exile. Once Ender knows, he is barred from Earth.

1.2 Rousseau's Captive Will

If Plato supplies the architecture, Rousseau supplies the method. The tutor of *Émile* (1762) educates negatively, never by precept, always by arranged experience, and the arrangement is to remain invisible. Let the child believe himself always the master, Rousseau counsels in Book II, while it is in truth the tutor who governs: "Il n'y a point d'assujettissement si parfait que celui qui garde l'apparence de la liberté; on captive ainsi la volonté même" (there is no subjection so perfect as that which preserves the appearance of freedom; in this way the will itself is taken captive). The tutor colludes with the gardener Robert to stage Émile's first lesson in property (Book II) and with a conjurer at a fair to stage a lesson in humility (Book III). Each lesson is a theater whose audience is also its unwitting lead.

Graff is Rousseau's tutor with an orbital laboratory. On the shuttle to Battle School he praises Ender publicly so that the other recruits will resent him (ch. 4); he and his staff alter the rules of the Battle Room to set Ender against impossible odds (ch. 11); he ensures that no adult will ever intervene on Ender's behalf, so that Ender will believe in his bones that he is alone. Each is a Rousseauian staging. The difference is teleological, and decisive. Rousseau's arranged experiences cultivate *amour de soi*, the self-love of a being sufficient to itself, and shield the child from *amour-propre*, the comparative self-regard that society inflames.

The administrators state the purpose of the staging in the dialogue that opens Chapter 4. Ender must be isolated enough to remain creative, lest he adopt the system and be lost to it, yet kept able to lead; and he must not be nice, since niceness would hand the war to the enemy. On the shuttle Graff executes the plan in public, declaring Ender the best of his launch, warning the others away from him, and reminding them that children have died at the school before (ch. 4). The remark is at once a threat, a prophecy, and a confession: the institution's director knows its body count.

In the *Discourse on Inequality* (1755) Rousseau locates the fall into *amour-propre* in the first public comparisons around the hut, when each began to watch the others and to wish to be watched, and public esteem acquired a price. The Battle School is that scene industrialized. Its standings board, its ranked armies, its posted scores, and its calculated alternation of praise and humiliation compose an engine of *amour-propre*. It retains Rousseau's method and inverts his end: the will is captured not to free it but to harness the very passion Rousseau held to be the origin of human misery.

1.3 The Strategic Child

The Battle School's ideology has a precise historical habitat. Lewis Terman's longitudinal *Genetic Studies of Genius* (from 1925) gave the twentieth century the figure of the measurably gifted child; Leta Hollingworth's *Children Above 180 IQ* (1942) gave it the figure of the profoundly gifted child stranded among peers. After Sputnik, the National Defense Education Act (1958) made the identification and training of talent in mathematics, science, and foreign languages an explicit matter of American national security, and the Marland Report (1972) supplied a federal definition of giftedness. Card's novel, conceived in the late 1960s and published in the Reagan years, arrives at the confluence: the child as strategic capital, measured, ranked, and mobilized against an existential adversary. The monitor implanted in Ender's neck is the psychometric gaze made literal. The novel's first words belong to an administrator reporting that he has seen and heard everything the boy has seen and heard, and the boy himself, when the device is removed, thinks of his life as a government experiment that has failed (ch. 1). The Battle School is the National Defense Education Act with its euphemisms removed.

The literary ancestor of this ideology is the Victorian school story, which had already imagined the playground as the anteroom of empire. The saying apocryphally attributed to the Duke of Wellington, that "the battle of Waterloo was won on the playing fields of Eton," condenses it. Thomas Hughes's *Tom Brown's School Days* (1857) married games to muscular Christianity. Rudyard Kipling's *Stalky & Co.* (1899), dedicated to the headmaster of the United Services College, closes with a coda in which a schoolboy stratagem reappears, unaltered, as a tactic on the North-West Frontier. Battle School is the playing field of Eton placed in orbit, with the frontier moved to another star system and the schoolboy stratagem promoted from prelude to decisive act.

1.4 Poisonous Pedagogy and the Total Institution

In 1977 Katharina Rutschky published *Schwarze Pädagogik*, an anthology of eighteenth- and nineteenth-century educational writings devoted to breaking the child's will for its own good. Alice Miller's *Am Anfang war Erziehung* (1980; in English as *For Your Own Good*, 1983) generalized the diagnosis into a theory of a pedagogy that disguises cruelty as care, requires the child to suppress knowledge of its own suffering, and thereby produces adults capable of inflicting what they cannot remember having endured. Miller's most notorious case study was the childhood of Adolf Hitler.

The juxtaposition transforms the first critical attack on the novel. Radford's analogy between Ender and Hitler has usually been read, by both sides, as an accu-

sation that the novel sympathizes with a genocidaire. Read through Miller, the analogy acquires a different and more disturbing sense. Ender resembles the Hitler of Miller's case study not because the novel apologizes for genocide but because it anatomizes the manufacture of a genocidal agent by a pedagogy of humiliation administered for the general good. The administrators' italicized dialogues that open each chapter document the regime with clinical candor: the boy must be isolated; he must never feel safe; he must believe that no adult will ever help him. The novel is less an apology for the xenocide than an etiology of the xenocidal instrument, and it places that etiology in plain view of the reader, who overhears the torturers deliberating.

The headnotes supply the regime's doctrine in its own words, and the doctrine hardens as the novel proceeds. The headnote to Chapter 5 holds that the boy's isolation must never be broken, since a single belief in rescue would ruin him. The headnote to Chapter 12, spoken as Bonzo's threat gathers, makes non-intervention a principle: the boy must believe absolutely that no adult will ever step in, whatever happens. Earlier, worrying over Ender's fixation on the Giant's Drink, the same administrators recall a former student who killed himself (ch. 6). The poisonous pedagogy is not an inference of the critic. It is minuted by its practitioners.

The establishment that administers this pedagogy is what Erving Goffman called a total institution (*Asylums*, 1961): one that gathers sleep, work, and play under a single roof and a single authority, processes its members in batches, and organizes every hour according to one official plan. Goffman's account of the inmate's mortification (the stripping of prior roles, the issued uniform, the new name, the privilege system) describes the induction of a launchy with precision. Foucault's *Discipline and Punish* (1975) supplies the complementary mechanism: hierarchical observation and normalizing judgment, fused in the examination, which converts each individual into a case.

The Battle School's distinctive refinement is that the examination is invisible as such. Ender never knows which of his acts are being graded, and the Fantasy Game examines even his unconscious. Life becomes the examination, until, in the final chapter, the examination becomes life.

1.5 Pedagogical Sovereignty

Platonic guardianship, Rousseau's captive will, the Cold War's strategic child, and the poisonous pedagogy converge in what I call *pedagogical sovereignty*: a regime in which the power to form a child is exercised with the prerogatives of the power to make war. Its signature is the identity of curriculum and campaign. It constitutes the first operation of pharmakotic sovereignty, consecration: the selection of an instrument, its separation from common life, and its formation under conditions of staged freedom that make its eventual act at once its own and not its own. That Ender's consecration begins before his birth, as a licensed exception to the population laws, means that its deepest roots are not pedagogical but theological. To these the next chapter turns.

2

CHAPTER TWO

Theologies of the Chosen

Foreordination, Agency, and the Economy of Ignorant Sin

Card is a member of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, a descendant of Brigham Young, a former missionary in Brazil, and the author of a body of work that repeatedly transposes Latter-day Saint scripture into speculative form. The *Homecoming* saga (1992–1995) retells the opening of the Book of Mormon as interstellar epic; the *Tales of Alvin Maker* (from 1987) refract the life of Joseph Smith through an alternate American frontier. *Ender's Game* wears its theology more lightly, yet it is saturated with it. The claim of this chapter is not that the novel is a Mormon allegory, which it is not, but that the doctrinal grammar in which Card was formed supplies the novel's moral categories, and that reconstructing that grammar dissolves several apparent puzzles in the critical debate.

The novel embeds this grammar in its hero's birth. In Chapter 3 Graff tells the six-year-old that his parents come from noncompliant families. His father was baptized John Paul Wieczorek, a Catholic, the seventh of nine children; his mother was a Mormon; both renounced their faiths, but ambivalently, and they regard their Third as proof both of their defiance of the law and of their accommodation to it. Graff adds that the father baptized each of his children as a Catholic as soon as he brought them home, and that the mother objected each time, not to baptism but to its Catholic form. The two religious traditions the population laws suppress stand at Ender's origin, quarreling over the rite whose timing, in Card's own tradition, marks a child's entry into accountability.

2.1 Foreordination Bureaucratized

In the Book of Abraham the prophet is shown the intelligences organized before the world was, among them many of "the noble and great ones," and is told: "thou wast chosen before thou wast born" (Abraham 3:22–23). The divine council then resolves to make an earth on which these spirits may dwell, adding: "we will prove them herewith" (3:24–25). Mortality, in this theology, is a probationary state (Alma 12:24; 42:4), a proving ground for spirits elected beforehand.

Ender is, with bureaucratic literalness, chosen before he was born. He is a Third, conceived under a government license (ch. 1). Graff explains the genealogy: Peter had been the most promising candidate the IF had seen in years but was passed over for reasons that, the opening dialogue says, had nothing to do with ability; the IF asked the parents for a daughter in hope of a milder Peter; Valentine proved too mild; and so the IF requisitioned a third child, to be, as Ender himself sums it up, half Peter and half Valentine (chs. 1, 3). The IF is a secularized pre-mortal council, the Battle School its probationary state, the battery of tests its proving "herewith." Yet the translation smuggles in a heresy. Latter-day Saint thought distinguishes foreordination from Calvinist predestination precisely by insisting that the elect remain free to fail: election is a calling, not a fate. The IF's foreordination admits no such freedom. It selects the child and then engineers the conditions under which his choices will produce the outcome the council requires. The theological structure is Mormon; the operative anthropology, of a will bound to an end decreed above it, is Calvin's.

2.2 The War in Heaven

The Pearl of Great Price preserves the Latter-day Saint account of the War in Heaven. Satan comes before God proposing to redeem all mankind, "that one soul shall not be lost," and asks in return for God's honor; he is cast down "because that Satan rebelled against me, and sought to destroy the agency of man" (Moses 4:1–3; cf. Abraham 3:27–28; Revelation 12:7–9). The Luciferian plan is defined by a precise exchange: universal salvation purchased by the abolition of agency.

The IF's plan is that exchange, executed. Humanity is saved entire, no soul lost to the Formics, at the price of the agency of one child, whose decisive act is extracted from him under a false description. Graff is not Satan; the novel takes pains to make him tender, burdened, and in his way devoted to Ender. But he occupies the structural position of the compulsive redeemer, and the novel permits his plan to succeed. That is the deepest theological scandal of *Ender's Game*, and it remains invisible until the book is read in the doctrinal key of its author: within Card's own cosmology, the plan that wins the war is the plan that lost the War in Heaven.

The Orthodox analogue is Dostoevsky's Grand Inquisitor (*The Brothers Karamazov*, 1880, Book V, ch. 5), who corrects Christ's work by relieving humanity of the burden of freedom through miracle, mystery, and authority, while a small elite consents to carry the knowledge from which the many are spared. Battle School deploys all three instruments: the miracle of its technology, the mystery of its concealments, the authority of its command. Graff and Mazer Rackham are the guardians of the mystery, and the novel's last chapter grants them the Inquisitor's portion. They keep the secret, win the war, and live with it.

2.3 Opposition in All Things

The Book of Mormon's most philosophically ambitious chapter teaches that "it must needs be, that there is an opposition in all things" (2 Nephi 2:11). Without opposition there could be neither righteousness nor wickedness, neither joy nor misery, and agency itself would be void; hence Adam fell that men might be (2:25). This is a theology of the fortunate fall more radical than the Augustinian *felix culpa*, because it makes opposition a structural condition of moral existence rather than an occasion for grace.

Mazer Rackham's pedagogy is its military translation. Taking charge of Ender at Command School, he announces himself as Ender's enemy and declares the adversary the only true instructor: only an enemy reveals your weakness, only an enemy teaches you to destroy (ch. 14). The doctrine descends from Heraclitus, for whom war is father and king of all (DK B53) and strife is justice (B80); it passes through Blake's "Opposition is true Friendship" (*The Marriage of Heaven and Hell*, plate 20) and the dialectic of recognition in Hegel's *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807, §§178–196).

The principle is older in the novel than Mazer. Its first page records the administrators' worry that Ender is too ready to submerge himself in another's will, unless the other is his enemy, and their resolution, if need be, to surround him with enemies at all times (ch. 1). Opposition is not a lesson Ender learns at Command School. It is the premise of his formation.

Read through Lehi's sermon, however, the doctrine generates a paradox the novel must resolve. If opposition is the condition of agency and joy, then annihilating the opponent is not merely a crime against the opponent but a self-inflicted metaphysical injury: the destruction of the condition of one's own moral existence. The xenocide abolishes the only other that could teach humanity what it is. It is for this reason, and not only out of sentiment, that the novel cannot end with victory. The enemy must be resurrected, in the form of the dormant Hive Queen, for moral life to resume. The coda is theologically necessary.

2.4 The Age of Accountability and the Economy of Ignorant Sin

Latter-day Saint doctrine fixes the age of accountability at eight (Doctrine and Covenants 68:25–27). Before it, little children cannot sin, for "power is not given unto Satan to tempt little children, until they begin to become accountable before me" (D&C 29:46–47); the Book of Mormon calls infant baptism a solemn mockery, since children are whole and alive in Christ (Moroni 8:8–12). Accountability, moreover, requires knowledge. Where there is no law given there is no punishment (2 Nephi 9:25–26), and the atonement covers those who die without law and those "who have ignorantly sinned" (Mosiah 3:11).

Ender kills Stilson at six, two years below the age at which, in Card's tradition, a child can sin at all. He kills Bonzo when barely ten (ch. 12) and the Formics at eleven (ch. 14), in both cases in ignorance of the particulars. The novel even places a contested baptism at its hero's origin, a dispute between his Catholic father and his Mormon mother over the very rite whose timing Moroni 8 makes a test of doctrine (ch. 3). The tradition thus furnishes Card with a fully articulated doctrine of non-accountability resting on two pillars, age and knowledge, and the novel's construction of Ender's innocence follows it exactly. What Kessel diagnoses as narrative rigging, the convenient arrangement of circumstances so that the hero never knowingly kills, is from inside Card's theological grammar a doctrine: innocence is not the absence of the act but the absence of accountability.

The doctrine explains the defense. It cannot explain the ending, in which Ender refuses the innocence his tradition would grant him. The explanation lies in the complementary doctrine of atonement. In Alma 7:11–12, Christ takes upon himself the pains, sicknesses, and infirmities of his people "that he may know according to the flesh how to succor his people according to their infirmities." Atonement here is an epistemic achievement: the acquisition, through suffering, of a knowledge of others from within. That is precisely the faculty Ender possesses and the IF exploits (Chapter 6). In the novel's world no Christ appears to carry the ignorant sin. Ender, who could claim the exemption of the child and of the ignorant, instead assumes the position of the one who takes on the sins of others and comes to know them according to the flesh. Read theologically, the novel's arc runs from the child who cannot sin to the man who atones.

2.5 Worlds Without Number and the Redemption of the Dead

Latter-day Saint cosmology is unusually hospitable to other worlds. God declares that "worlds without number have I created" (Moses 1:33), and the inhabitants of those worlds are "begotten sons and daughters unto God" (D&C 76:24). In such a cosmos the alien is in principle kin, and xenocide shades into fratricide; the first murder in Genesis is the archetype of the last. The novel makes the kinship literal at the molecular level. Graff tells Ender that the buggers could have evolved on Earth had things gone differently a billion years ago, that their genetic material is the same as that of terrestrial life, and that their insect-like appearance is no accident (ch. 13). The novel's familial structure registers the echo. Ender is a third child, as Seth was "another seed instead of Abel, whom Cain slew" (Genesis 4:25), born into a household whose firstborn has threatened to kill him.

The tradition also binds the salvation of the dead to that of the living. Joseph Smith's epistle on baptism for the dead declares that "they without us cannot be made perfect—neither can we without our dead be made perfect" (D&C 128:15; cf. Hebrews 11:40) and calls for a "welding link" between the generations (128:18). The coda of *Ender's Game* enacts a secular version of this doctrine. Ender carries the pupal queen in search of a world where she may awaken; he speaks the truth of her people's life; his redemption and hers are made mutually conditional. The Speaker for the Dead is a vicarious ordinance without a temple. The later novels' metaphysics of the *aiúa*, the uncreated core of every being, draws on the related teaching that intelligence "was not created or made, neither indeed can be" (D&C 93:29); its seed is already present here.

2.6 A Theodicy Without God

The Latter-day Saint grammar furnishes three of the operations of pharmakotic sovereignty: consecration as foreordination, occultation as the production of non-accountability, and testimony as the redemption of the dead. It also exposes the novel's central theological tension. Card's theology condemns compulsion as the Luciferian plan; his plot rewards it. The coda is the repair: an atonement that cannot restore the agency the war destroyed, and therefore restores agency in the only form still available, as the free assumption of responsibility for a deed one did not choose. *Ender's Game* is a theodicy from which God has withdrawn, in which a human apparatus occupies in turn the positions of the council, the adversary, and the redeemer, and in which atonement must be performed by the victim of the plan that required it.

3

CHAPTER THREE

The Grammar of Enmity

From Polemos to the Absolute Enemy

The Formic War is the novel's premise and its least examined philosophical object. It is usually treated as scenery, the necessary pretext for a story about a child. It is in fact a condensed history of Western thinking about enmity, in which nearly every major theory of war, sovereignty, and the enemy meets an experimental limit-case: an adversary with whom no speech is possible, a threat that may or may not recur, and a weapon that ends not a war but a species. This chapter reconstructs that history and identifies the novel's distinctive contribution to it: the sovereign decision without a sovereign decider.

3.1 Polemos and the Strategists

Thucydides has the Athenians justify their empire by three compulsions, fear, honor, and interest (1.75–76), and the first of these governs the novel. The Formic War is a war of fear in Thucydides' exact sense. The Third Invasion, humanity's assault on the Formic homeworld, is launched not because the Formics are attacking but because humanity cannot know that they will not. Graff tells Ender that as soon as the IF had a working ansible it placed one in each of its best ships and launched them against the enemy's home systems, long before any commander existed to direct them, and that the decision was kept from the public nets so that no one could second-guess it (ch. 13). The Melian Dialogue (5.84–116), in which Athens instructs a small island that the strong do what they can and the weak endure what they must (5.89), ends with the killing of the Melian men and the enslavement of the women and children (5.116). The xenocide is Melos at the scale of a species, with one difference: the Formics were offered no dialogue, because neither side could recognize the other as a party to one.

Sun Tzu teaches that one who knows the enemy and knows himself need not fear a hundred battles, and that the supreme excellence is to break the enemy's resistance without fighting (*The Art of War*, ch. 3). Ender's method is Sunzian to the root: his victories proceed from a knowledge of the adversary so complete that it borders on identification. His end is anti-Sunzian. He does not seek to subdue without fighting; he seeks to fight so totally that no fighting can follow.

Clausewitz's *On War* (1832) supplies the frame for this inversion. War, by its pure concept, tends through reciprocal escalation toward the absolute (I.1); real war is moderated by the political purpose it continues by other means (I.1.24), and by friction and uncertainty. Where the enemy lies beyond all communication, however, there is no policy to continue and no political purpose to moderate the escalation. War ceases to be the continuation of politics and becomes the continuation of biology. The Formic War is Clausewitz's absolute war made real by the subtraction of the political interlocutor, and Ender is its Clausewitzian genius, distinguished by the coup d'oeil that grasps a situation at a glance and the resolution to act on it (I.3).

Card's acknowledged source, Bruce Catton's history of the Army of the Potomac, adds the American chapter. Catton's narrative is in large part the story of Lincoln's search for a commander who would fight: McClellan, a superb organizer unwilling to risk his army, is succeeded in the end by Grant, who would accept terrible losses for a decisive result. The IF's quest is Lincoln's search transposed, and Graff names its models himself: the world, he tells the six-year-old on the shuttle, needs a Napoleon or an Alexander, though Napoleon lost in the end and Alexander burned out and died young (ch. 4). It needs a Grant, a commander who will spend his ships and their crews to reach the enemy's heart. The novel's grim refinement is the discovery that the only reliable way to produce such a commander from an empathetic child is to ensure that he does not know he is spending anything.

Ender's command style anticipates the doctrines that reshaped Western militaries in the decade of the novel's publication: the Prussian *Auftragstaktik*, in which subordinates act on the commander's intent rather than detailed orders, and John Boyd's theory of the decision cycle and of the creative destruction of obsolete concepts ("Destruction and Creation," 1976). The novel's long presence on United States Marine Corps professional reading lists is the institutional acknowledgment of this affinity.

3.2 The State of War: Hobbes and Locke

Hobbes taught that war consists not in actual fighting but in "the known disposition thereto" (*Leviathan*, 1651, ch. 13), and that the remedy for a natural condition in which life is "solitary, poor, nasty, brutish, and short" is a common power that keeps all in awe. The Formic threat functions in the novel as that common power. It is the known disposition to war, sustained through decades of quiet, that holds the Hegemony together and keeps the Warsaw Pact in check. Peter reads the structure while the war is still being fought: tracking Warsaw Pact troop movements, he concludes that the Pact is preparing for the war after the war (ch. 9). When the threat is annihilated, the terrestrial blocs fall upon one another at once in the League War, which ends only in a truce on the terms of the Locke Proposal, under which the IF survives without the Warsaw Pact (ch. 15). The real sovereign of Card's Earth is not the Hegemon but the enemy.

Locke is more precise still, and the novel names him. In the chapter "Of the State of War" in the *Second Treatise* (1689), Locke argues that one who declares by word or deed a design upon another's life places himself in a state of war with him and may be destroyed "for the same reason that he may kill a wolf or a lion," since such aggressors are not under the ties of the common law of reason and may be treated as beasts of prey (§16). The Lockean state of war is constituted by the absence of shared reason with the aggressor. This is the precise logic by which the Formics, with whom no common law of reason can be established because no language is shared, may be destroyed as beasts. It is also the logic Ender applies to Stilson and to Bonzo, each of whom has declared a design upon his life. The pseudonym Peter chooses for his public career names the doctrine on which the whole plot runs.

The irony is doubled. Peter's Locke is the voice of liberal moderation, the statesman of compromise; the historical Locke's doctrine of the state of war is a doctrine of the exterminable enemy. And the same Locke, in the chapter "Of Conquest" (§§175–196), limits the despotic power of a just conqueror to those who actually assisted in the unjust war, exempting their wives, children, and estates. A hive dissolves that limitation. Where every worker is a limb of the queen, there are no noncombatants, and the principle of discrimination that Locke's limitation anticipates finds no purchase. The Formic War is the case in which the Lockean doctrine of the state of war applies fully and the Lockean doctrine of conquest not at all. The novel's ethics is forged in the gap between them.

3.3 Demosthenes and the Hegemon: The Greek Grammar of Command

The titles of the novel's supreme offices are Greek. The Strategos holds overall command of the IF, the Polemarch commands its fleet, and the Hegemon presides over the human alliance (ch. 8). The first two named Athenian military magistracies; the third named the leader of a league, and its most consequential bearer was Philip II of Macedon, who after his victory at Chaeronea (338 BCE) became hegemon of the League of Corinth. The orator who had spent his career warning Athens against Philip was Demosthenes, whose *Philippics* became the type of the speech of resistance to a rising power.

Card's onomastics re-stage that struggle inside a single family. Valentine writes as Demosthenes; Peter writes as Locke and will become Hegemon. The rhetoric of resistance to hegemony becomes the ladder by which hegemony is climbed: Demosthenes' alarms about the Warsaw Pact create the climate in which Locke's moderation looks statesmanlike, and Valentine, the gentle sibling, lends her voice to fear while Peter, the cruel one, lends his to peace (ch. 9). The lesson is that political rhetoric is detachable from character, a lesson as old as Machiavelli's counsel that the prince need not possess the virtues but must seem to (*The Prince*, ch. 18). The pseudonymous tradition the Wiggin children join (Publius of *The Federalist*, the *Cato's Letters* of Trenchard and Gordon, the anonymous Junius) is the tradition in which political speech acquires authority by severing itself from the speaker's person. Chapter 10 returns to that severance.

The Macedonian pattern extends beyond the pseudonyms. The Alexander whom Graff seeks (3.1) was the son of the hegemon Philip, and the novel's family plot gives Earth its Philip in Peter and its conqueror in Ender. The offices are also sites of struggle within the apparatus: Major Anderson threatens to report Graff's orders to the Strategos and the Hegemon, and accuses him of keeping the Polemarch in his pocket (ch. 8). The novel even attaches a secular myth of election to the hierarchy, recording a belief that Jewish generals do not lose wars, which had made the office of Strategos a Jewish preserve; yet the victory of the Second Invasion belonged to Mazer Rackham, a little-known, twice court-martialed, half-Maori New Zealander (ch. 8). The savior is an outsider whom the institution has twice tried to discipline, as it will try Graff after the next war.

3.4 Schmitt: Humanity and Its Enemy

Carl Schmitt defined the specifically political distinction as that between friend and enemy (*The Concept of the Political*, 1927/1932). The enemy is the other, the stranger, existentially different in an intense sense, and a political entity exists only where the real possibility of such an enemy exists. From this Schmitt drew a conclusion with an astronomical clause: humanity as such cannot wage war, because it has no enemy, "at least not on this planet." The Formic War realizes Schmitt's counterfactual. An enemy from beyond the planet makes humanity, for the first time, a political unit; the Hegemony is humanity become a Schmittian polity.

Schmitt also warned that wars waged in the name of humanity are peculiarly inhuman, because they deny the enemy the quality of being human and thereby license unlimited means; adapting Proudhon, he held that whoever invokes humanity is preparing to deceive. In *Theory of the Partisan* (1963) he distinguished the conventional enemy of bounded interstate war, the real enemy of the defensive partisan, and the absolute enemy whom ideology criminalizes and marks for annihilation. The Formics are absolute enemies by nature rather than ideology: they are not human, and they cannot speak. The final revelation shows that this absoluteness was a projection of epistemic incapacity. The Formics were real enemies who had attacked, then understood, then withdrawn; humanity, unable to hear them, destroyed a former enemy as an absolute one.

The aftermath supplies a corollary I call the *conservation of enmity*. When the external enemy is annihilated, enmity does not vanish; it returns inward. The League War breaks out on Earth as soon as the Formic threat is gone (ch. 15). Schmitt's thesis predicts precisely this: a humanity without an enemy ceases to be a political unit and decomposes into the units its enmity had suspended.

3.5 Kant: The Peace of the Graveyard

Kant opened *Toward Perpetual Peace* (1795) with a joke: a Dutch innkeeper's sign, bearing the essay's title, displayed a churchyard. The joke becomes doctrine in the Sixth Preliminary Article, which forbids hostilities that would make mutual trust impossible in a future peace, since a war of extermination would permit perpetual peace only "auf dem großen Kirchhofe der Menschengattung," on the vast graveyard of the human race (8:347). The xenocide achieves exactly that peace, for another species. Humanity's peace is purchased on the Formic graveyard, and the last chapter shows humanity literally settling it, as colonists move onto the worlds the Formics had prepared for themselves.

Three further Kantian texts sharpen the case. The Third Definitive Article grounds a cosmopolitan right of hospitality, the right of a stranger not to be treated

with hostility upon arrival (8:357–358); neither species extended it in life. The novel's last pages extend it in death: the book Ender writes in the queen's voice welcomes the human colonists to the emptied worlds as guest-friends (ch. 15), a posthumous hospitality to which Chapter 11 returns. The *Anthropology from a Pragmatic Point of View* (1798) observes that the character of the human species cannot be fully determined, because we lack acquaintance with any non-terrestrial rational beings against which to compare it (7:321). The Formics supply Kant's missing term of comparison, and the comparison issues in war. Finally, the Formula of Humanity commands that rational nature, in oneself and in others, never be treated merely as a means (*Groundwork*, 4:429). The formula speaks of rational nature, not of the human species, and it covers the Formics. The novel thus presents a double violation of a single principle: the Formics destroyed as if they were things, and Ender used as if he were one.

3.6 Just War, Supreme Emergency, and Prevention

Augustine held that the wise man will wage just wars yet lament the necessity of doing so (*City of God* XIX.7), and that war is waged for the sake of peace (Letter 189). Aquinas specified legitimate authority, just cause, and right intention (*Summa Theologiae* II-II q.40). Ender satisfies right intention to a fault; he is a mourning Augustinian warrior. Legitimate authority is precisely what the novel complicates, since the authority that wages the war is not the agent who fights it.

Michael Walzer's *Just and Unjust Wars* appeared in 1977, the year of the novelette. Its doctrine of supreme emergency (ch. 16) holds that a threat both imminent and of an unusual and horrifying kind may justify overriding the rules of war, but only while the emergency lasts: Walzer is prepared to defend the British bombing of German cities in 1940 and 1941, not the British and American firebombing of Dresden in February 1945, which killed some twenty-five thousand people. His chapter on anticipation distinguishes legitimate preemption, in the face of manifest intent and active preparation, from illegitimate prevention. The Third Invasion falls on the wrong side of both distinctions. It is undertaken against an enemy that had, unknown to humanity, already resolved never to return. It is Dresden, not 1940; prevention, not preemption. The novel registers the point in its hero's own thought: watching Graff's trial, Ender reflects that the beings he destroyed had not even attacked a third time, and that no one thinks to call their destruction a crime (ch. 15).

The preventive logic has a notorious Cold War voice. John von Neumann, a founder of game theory, is reported to have urged a preventive nuclear strike against the Soviet Union, asking why one should wait for tomorrow to do what

could be done today. Robert Axelrod's *The Evolution of Cooperation* (1984), published a year before the novel, showed by contrast that cooperation among self-interested agents emerges when the future casts a sufficient shadow over the present. The doctrine Ender gives Graff to explain why he kept kicking Stilson after he had already knocked him down, that he must win not this fight but all future ones now (ch. 3), is the exact antithesis of Axelrod's finding. It abolishes the shadow of the future by annihilating the future opponent. That doctrine, enlarged by orders of magnitude, is the strategy of the Third Invasion.

3.7 The Bomb and the Gita

The Little Doctor, so named by a fleet joke on its formal designation, the Molecular Detachment Device, whose initials suggested a physician (ch. 14), shares a diminutive with Little Boy, the bomb the United States dropped on Hiroshima on 6 August 1945, killing tens of thousands of people at once, and its planet-consuming chain reaction recalls the fear, examined in the Los Alamos report LA-602 (1946), that a fission explosion might ignite the atmosphere. J. Robert Oppenheimer later recalled that at the Trinity test a line of the Bhagavad Gita came to him, "Now I am become Death, the destroyer of worlds," his rendering of Krishna's self-revelation as Time full-grown, the destroyer of worlds (Gita 11.32).

The Gita's theology of the warrior bears directly on Ender. Arjuna, despondent on the field of Kurukshetra, is taught to act without attachment to the fruits of action (2.47), and in the theophany of the eleventh chapter Krishna reveals that the enemy warriors are already slain by Time; Arjuna is to be merely the instrument, *nimitta-mātram bhava* (11.33). Ender is the instrument in the most literal sense. But the Gita absolves its instrument by revelation: Arjuna is shown the cosmic form and acts with full knowledge of what he does and why. The IF absolves its instrument by concealment: Ender is shown a simulation and acts without knowledge of what he does. The modern apparatus inverts the ancient theology of the innocent instrument, replacing theophany with occultation.

3.8 The Dark Forest Anticipated

Liu Cixin's *The Dark Forest* (2008) formalizes a cosmic sociology in which survival is the primary need of every civilization, intentions cannot be verified across interstellar distance, and the possibility of sudden technological advance makes every detected civilization a mortal threat; the rational strategy is therefore to strike first. *Ender's Game* anticipates this logic and corrects it. The Formics broke the chain of suspicion unilaterally: having understood that humans were sentient, they resolved never to return. But they could not say so. The tragedy is not cosmic necessity but asymmetric information. Card's universe is not a dark forest; it is a forest in which a lantern was lit too late to be seen.

3.9 Synthesis: The Decision Without a Decider

Schmitt defined the sovereign as the one who decides on the exception (*Political Theology*, 1922). The Formic War presents a decision of maximal exceptionality, the annihilation of a species, and the novel's peculiar achievement is to show that decision taken by no one. The Hegemony authorizes the war; the IF designs the examination; the pilots execute maneuvers they know to be real; the child makes the decisive move believing it a game. Each contributes, and none decides. The xenocide is a sovereign decision without a sovereign decider. That configuration is the political form of pharmakotic sovereignty, and its condition is the manufacture of an agent who acts without knowing. Before turning to the anatomy of that manufacture, the next chapter situates the novel among the works of speculative and philosophical fiction with which it is in conversation.

4

CHAPTER FOUR

The Speculative Field

Ender's Game Among Its Interlocutors

Ender's Game belongs to several traditions at once, and its distinctiveness emerges only when it is placed among them. This chapter maps six constellations of speculative and philosophical fiction with which the novel is in conversation, by descent, by contemporaneity, or by later response. It concludes with a typology organized around the variable the novel isolates more radically than any of its interlocutors: what the instrument knows.

4.1 The Military Bildungsroman: Heinlein and Haldeman

Robert A. Heinlein's *Starship Troopers* (1959) is the novel's most obvious ancestor. Its narrator, Juan Rico, volunteers for the Mobile Infantry, survives the brutal training of Camp Currie, and fights the Arachnids, a hive species organized in castes under a controlling brain caste. Heinlein's moral philosophy is taught openly, in a classroom: the course in History and Moral Philosophy argues that force has settled more questions than any other factor and that the franchise must be earned by service. Card keeps the training-camp structure and reimagines Heinlein's Bugs as buggers. But he reverses the epistemology. Rico consents, knows what the war is, and receives its doctrine explicitly; Ender is deceived, and the doctrine of his war is administered through structures he cannot see. Heinlein's Bugs remain an exterminable surface; Card makes the interiority of the hive his novel's final revelation.

Joe Haldeman's *The Forever War* (1974), written by a veteran of Vietnam, answered Heinlein with an allegory of that war. William Mandella is drafted into an elite of the gifted, fights the Taurans through a war that relativistic time dilation stretches across more than a millennium, and returns each time to an Earth that no longer recognizes him. The war, it emerges, rested on a misunderstanding, and it

ends when humanity, having become a cloned collective, can at last communicate with the Taurans, who are clones themselves. Card retains the misunderstanding and the time-dilated exile, which becomes Ender's condition in the coda. He forecloses the communicative ending. In Haldeman the group mind makes peace possible; in Card the group mind speaks only after it has been annihilated. Haldeman's war ends by communication; Card's ends by annihilation, followed by communication with the dead.

4.2 The Child as Instrument: Golding, Vonnegut, Ishiguro, and the Arena

William Golding's *Lord of the Flies* (1954) is the great modern fable of children's violence, and its theology is one of original sin revealed by the absence of adults. Marooned without supervision, the boys reconstruct savagery, and the novel ends with a naval officer whose rescue is itself an episode in a larger war. Card inverts the premise. In *Ender's Game* the violence of children is produced not by the absence of adults but by their total presence. Golding's officer, a single figure of irony on the last page, becomes Card's chorus, deliberating at the head of every chapter.

Kurt Vonnegut's *Slaughterhouse-Five* (1969) carries the subtitle *The Children's Crusade*, a promise made to a friend's wife who protested that the men who fought the war had been little more than babies. The medieval crusade of children supplies the type, and Battle School is its literalization. Vonnegut's protagonist, loosed from chronology by his Tralfamadorian education, has a successor in Ender, whom relativistic travel will loose from history.

Kazuo Ishiguro's *Never Let Me Go* (2005) offers the closest later analogue to the novel's ethics of disclosure. The students of Hailsham are raised as organ donors and "told and not told" what they are for; one guardian believes they must be told plainly, while the institution's leadership defends partial concealment as the gift of a childhood. The debate among Ender's administrators, recorded in the chapter headnotes, is the same debate. Ishiguro also shares Card's resolution in an aesthetic artifact: the guardians gathered the students' art to prove they had souls, as the Speaker's book proves the Formics had them.

A later lineage turns the child combatant into spectacle. Koushun Takami's *Battle Royale* (1999) and Suzanne Collins's *The Hunger Games* (2008) stage killing among children for a watching audience. Hideaki Anno's *Neon Genesis Evangelion* (1995–1996) sends adolescents to pilot war machines against enigmatic adversaries whose nature adult institutions conceal, and reframes the collective mind, in its "Human Instrumentality" project, as humanity's own terminal temptation rather than its enemy.

4.3 The Prodigy and the Group Mind: Stapledon, Sturgeon, Clarke, Wyndham, Herbert

Olaf Stapledon's *Odd John* (1935) is the founding text of the supernormal child who legislates his own ethics. John kills when he judges it necessary, without remorse, and the colony of his kind is ultimately destroyed by ordinary humanity. Ender is Odd John with remorse, and the difference is the novel's moral center. Stapledon's *Star Maker* (1937) populates the cosmos with telepathic group minds and composite intelligences, establishing the speculative premise that mind may reside at scales other than the individual. Theodore Sturgeon's *More Than Human* (1953) assembles a *homo gestalt* from misfit children and makes its moral education the plot: the gestalt must acquire an ethic. Arthur C. Clarke's *Childhood's End* (1953) ends with humanity's children merging into a cosmic Overmind, the child as the vessel of a species' transformation.

John Wyndham's *The Midwich Cuckoos* (1957) is the novel's most exact inverse. Alien-begotten children who share a single mind threaten humanity, and the elderly schoolmaster Gordon Zellaby, their one adult friend, destroys them and himself with explosives he brings to a film showing. A beloved teacher, a screening, the annihilation of a collective mind: these are the elements of Card's climax, recombined. In Wyndham the teacher knows and the hive dies in a classroom; in Card the child does not know and the hive dies in its home. Both novels ask whether the preemptive annihilation of a collective intelligence can be justified. Wyndham answers once, with the act. Card answers twice, first with the act and then with the Speaker.

Frank Herbert's *Dune* (1965) supplies the prodigy's other face. Paul Atreides is the product of a centuries-long breeding program, a consecration by genetics that rhymes with Ender's licensed birth. He passes the gom jabbar, a test that distinguishes the human from the animal by the capacity to endure pain without flight, and he foresees a holy war in his name that he cannot prevent. Paul's pathology is prescience; Ender's is nescience. One knows and cannot stop the slaughter; the other stops nothing because he does not know. Herbert said he wrote the novel to warn against charismatic heroes. *Ender's Game* reads as the companion warning against the apparatus that manufactures them.

4.4 The Ethics of Contact: Le Guin, Lem, Chiang, Butler

Card borrowed the ansible from Ursula K. Le Guin, who coined the word in *Rocannon's World* (1966) and grounded the device in Shevek's physics in *The Dispossessed* (1974). The borrowing marks a philosophical opposition. Le Guin's Ekumen practices non-coercive contact: in *The Left Hand of Darkness* (1969) Genly Ai arrives alone, because one envoy cannot be a threat. Card's IF practices contact through a fleet. The novel even acknowledges the borrowing inside its fiction: Graff explains that the device's official name is the Philotic Parallax Instantaneous Communicator, and that its common name was retrieved from an old book (ch. 13). In "The Word for World Is Forest" (1972), Le Guin's Vietnam allegory, the Athshean Selver learns killing from the colonists and becomes, in his people's idiom, a god: one who brings a new thing into the world and must carry it. Ender's later vocation answers to the same description.

Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973) is the novel's most important philosophical interlocutor. The happiness of Omelas depends on the misery of one child kept in a cellar; every citizen knows; some walk away. Le Guin credited the conception to William James, who asked in "The Moral Philosopher and the Moral Life" (1891) whether millions could accept their happiness on condition that "a certain lost soul on the far-off edge of things" endure a life of lonely torture; she later named the scapegoat as the story's central idea. Behind both stands Ivan Karamazov, who refuses a harmony built on the unavenged tears of a single tortured child and returns his ticket. *Ender's Game* is the Omelas in which the citizens do not know, the child does not know, and the cellar is in orbit. No one walks away. Instead the child, once he knows, walks back toward the dead.

Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* (1961), *His Master's Voice* (1968), and *Fiasco* (1986) form a counter-tradition of xenological skepticism, in which the alien may be inaccessible in principle and anthropocentric projection drives catastrophe; in *Fiasco* a human expedition misreads the signals of the planet Quinta and devastates it. Ted Chiang's "Story of Your Life" (1998) offers the optimistic counterpart: a linguist who learns the heptapods' writing acquires their simultaneous apprehension of time and chooses a future whose grief she already knows. Chiang's contact succeeds because language is learned; Card's fails because neither party recognizes the other's medium as language.

Octavia E. Butler's Xenogenesis trilogy (*Dawn*, 1987; *Adulthood Rites*, 1988; *Imago*, 1989) diagnoses in humanity a lethal Human Contradiction: intelligence placed in the service of older hierarchical drives. Battle School is the Human Contradiction institutionalized, an apparatus for ranking intelligence in the service of hierarchy and war.

4.5 The Philosophical Tale: Huxley, Orwell, Kafka, Dick

Aldous Huxley's *Brave New World* (1932) opens in a Hatchery and Conditioning Centre where reproduction is a function of the state; Ender, licensed into existence, is the Hatchery's individual product. George Orwell's *Nineteen Eighty-Four* (1949) explains perpetual war as an instrument of domestic order, waged by each ruling group against its own subjects as much as against any enemy. The Formic War is Orwell's war allowed to end, and its ending exposes the Orwellian function at once: deprived of its enemy, Earth collapses into civil war. Franz Kafka's *The Metamorphosis* (1915) and Philip K. Dick's *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968) are taken up in Chapters 7 and 6 respectively, Kafka for the household that flourishes after the death of its insect, Dick for the test that makes empathy the criterion of the human.

4.6 The Game as Empire: Banks

Iain M. Banks's *The Player of Games* (1988) is the novel's structural twin. Jernau Gurgeh, the Culture's greatest game-player, is maneuvered by its covert agency, Special Circumstances, into playing Azad, a game so complex that it constitutes the political order of an empire. His victory brings the empire down, and the extent of his instrumentalization is disclosed only afterward, by a narration whose source proves to lie within the manipulating apparatus itself. The game as empire, the player as unwitting weapon, the benevolent intelligence that arranges everything: every element is Card's. The difference lies in the politics of the manipulator. Banks's Culture is a post-scarcity liberal utopia whose manipulations are framed as liberation; Card's IF is a desperate militarized state whose manipulations are framed as survival.

4.7 A Typology of Instruments

Table 1 organizes the field around the variable the novel isolates: the instrument's knowledge of its own act.

Table 1. *The instrument and its knowledge across the speculative field*

Work (year)	Instrument	What the instrument knows	Outcome
Kipling, *Stalky & Co.* (1899)	Schoolboys trained as imperial officers	That school prepares them; not the empire's ends	A schoolboy stratagem reappears on the frontier
Golding, *Lord of the Flies* (1954)	Marooned boys	Their own violence, with no adult design	Rescue by an officer engaged in a larger war
Wyndham, *The Midwich Cuckoos* (1957)	Gordon Zellaby, schoolmaster	Everything; he plans the act	A collective mind annihilated; the teacher dies with it
Heinlein, *Starship Troopers* (1959)	Juan Rico, volunteer	The war and its doctrine, taught openly	Consent affirmed; the war continues
Herbert, *Dune* (1965)	Paul Atreides, bred by an order	Foresees the holy war his victory unleashes	Prescience without the power to prevent
Dick, *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968)	Rick Deckard, bounty hunter	That he kills beings defined by a lack of empathy	The empathy criterion destabilized
Haldeman, *The Forever War* (1974)	William Mandella, conscript	That the war is real; not its origin	Peace once communication becomes possible
Card, *Ender's Game* (1985)	**Ender Wiggin**	**Believes the war is a simulation**	**Xenocide, then testimony for the dead**
Lem, *Fiasco* (1986)	The expedition to Quinta	Misreads the alien signals	Devastation; contact as catastrophe
Banks, *The Player of Games* (1988)	Jernau Gurgeh	That he plays; not what his play is for	An empire falls; the manipulation disclosed afterward
Chiang, "Story of Your Life" (1998)	Louise Banks, linguist	Her entire future	Contact succeeds; a known grief is chosen
Ishiguro, *Never Let Me Go* (2005)	The Hailsham students	Partly, by institutional design	Completion without revolt
Liu, *The Dark Forest* (2008)	Luo Ji, Wallfacer	A strategy he conceals from everyone	Deterrence by the threat of cosmic exposure

Three distinctive contributions emerge. First, Card alone makes the instrument's ignorance the condition of the act's success: Heinlein's soldier consents, Haldeman's conscript knows the war is real, Wyndham's teacher plans, Herbert's hero foresees, Banks's player knows that he plays. Second, Card alone joins the annihilation to a subsequent ministry of the annihilator to the annihilated; the Speaker has no precedent in the field. Third, Card locates the catastrophe of contact neither in the alien's unknowability, as Lem does, nor in a failure of language as such, as Chiang's success implies by contrast, but in the asynchrony between recognition and act. The Formics understood too late to be heard; Ender understood too late to

refrain. *Ender's Game* is the field's purest tragedy of timing and its purest study of manufactured nescience. The anatomy of that nescience is the task of Part II.

PART

II

Anatomies

5

CHAPTER FIVE

The Inverted Cave

Simulation, Nescience, and the Manufacture of Innocence

The first operation of pharmakotic sovereignty selects and forms its instrument; the second blinds it. This chapter anatomizes occultation, the production in an agent of maximal capacity of ignorance about the particulars of his own act. It argues that *Ender's Game* inverts the founding allegory of Western epistemology, that the inversion yields a structure distinct from the simulation theory with which the novel is usually compared, and that the innocence it produces is not a moral property discovered after the act but an epistemic condition engineered before it.

5.1 The Architecture of Concealment

The novel nests its simulations with deliberate escalation. The monitor in Ender's neck (ch. 1) makes the child's perception the state's; the Battle Room simulates war in weightlessness; the Fantasy Game simulates a psyche and reads its responses; the simulator at Command School simulates fleet combat. The sequence runs from simulations of reality to a reality disguised as simulation, and the hinge is so smooth that neither the protagonist nor the first-time reader feels it turn.

Two details perfect the disguise. First, Mazer Rackham presents himself as the author of the enemy's maneuvers in the simulator, so that Ender believes he is playing against his teacher. The teacher's persona is the mask behind which the real enemy acts: the Formic queens are personated, in Hobbes's sense (Chapter 10), by the man who taught Ender to destroy them. Mazer confirms it after the battle: from the moment he declared himself Ender's enemy, Ender never played against him, and never played a game at all (ch. 14). Second, the ansible abolishes latency. Real combat across interstellar distance would announce its reality through the delay of every signal; instantaneous communication erases the one phenomenological mark

by which the remote real differs from the local simulation. The ansible is not merely the device that makes the deception possible. It is the technology of indistinguishability itself. Its secrecy is part of its function; Graff observes that most people do not even know the machine exists (ch. 13). It is also double-edged, for the coda reveals that the queens found Ender through the same ansible and came to know him in his dreams (ch. 15).

5.2 Plato's Cave, Reversed

In the allegory of the *Republic* (514a–520a), prisoners chained since childhood take the shadows cast on a wall for the only reality; one is freed, turned toward the fire, dragged into the sunlight, and later made to descend and govern those still below. The Battle School is a cave whose children are not chained but immersed, facing not a wall but screens. The decisive difference is that its shadows are real. The children take reality for shadow and the war for its image.

The consequences of the inversion are exact. In Plato, the turn toward the real is an ascent; in Card, it is a descent, a fall from a world of games into the knowledge of what the games were. In Plato, knowledge liberates; in Card, it condemns. In Plato, the one who has seen the sun must be compelled to return and rule; in Card, the one who has seen it is forbidden to return to Earth. Graff explains that the boy is dangerous precisely because he could so easily be controlled; Peter wanted him brought home under the protection of a council that Peter effectively commanded; it was Locke who argued publicly that Ender should remain on Eros, a position Graff hints that Demosthenes had induced; and Ender's own plea to come home is censored from the broadcasts (ch. 15). I call this structure the *inverted cave*: an epistemic regime in which the real is concealed not behind appearance but as appearance, and in which release from ignorance is experienced as catastrophe rather than illumination.

The novel states the inversion in so many words. In the weeks of the final campaign Ender's nights become so vivid that his days begin to seem like dreams, as though someone were riding him in his sleep through his worst memories (ch. 14). The coda names the rider: the queens, who had followed the ansible into his mind (ch. 15). The cave's prisoner is not only deceived by his guardians; he is visited, in the only medium the enemy commands, by those he is killing.

5.3 The Crypto-Real

The novel is often compared with Jean Baudrillard's account of the precession of simulacra, in which the map precedes the territory and the real dissolves into the hyperreal (*Simulacra and Simulation*, 1981), and with his provocation that the Gulf War, experienced by Western publics as a sequence of screened images, did not take place (1991). The comparison is apt as far as it goes, but the novel's structure is the reverse of Baudrillard's. In Baudrillard the simulacrum absorbs the real. In Card the real survives intact inside the simulacrum, hidden as its content, and returns with full force when the disguise is removed. I call this structure the *crypto-real*: the real encrypted as simulation. Its theorists are less Baudrillard than Paul Virilio, whose *War and Cinema* (1984) traced the fusion of weapon and camera into a logistics of perception, and Grégoire Chamayou, whose *Théorie du drone* (2013) analyzes remote killing as the production of a radical asymmetry that removes the killer from danger and the killed from reciprocity.

The novel's prescience on this point is now a commonplace of military ethics. A United Nations report on targeted killings warned in 2010 against a "PlayStation mentality" in remote warfare. Harun Farocki's installations *Serious Games* (2009–2010) documented the same simulation software used to train soldiers before deployment and to treat their trauma afterward, so that the screen precedes and follows the war. Ender at his console, ansible-linked to distant ships, killing through an interface identical to the one on which he trained, is the founding image of that regime. The novel adds what the documentary record cannot: the case in which the operator is not merely desensitized by the interface but deceived by it.

5.4 Aristotle on Ignorance

The philosophical analysis of Ender's condition begins with the third book of the *Nicomachean Ethics*. Aristotle holds that acts done through ignorance are not voluntary, but that only those followed by pain and regret are involuntary (*akousia*); acts done through ignorance and not regretted are merely non-voluntary (1110b18–24). He distinguishes ignorance of the universal, of what one ought to do, which is culpable and constitutes vice, from ignorance of particulars: who acts, what he is doing, to what or to whom, with what instrument, for what end, and in what manner (1110b28–1111a20). His examples are uncannily apposite. One might mistake one's son for an enemy, believe a pointed spear to be buttoned, or give someone a drink to save him and kill him instead (1111a11–14).

Ender's ignorance is entirely of particulars. He does not know what he is doing (killing, not playing), to whom he does it (living Formics, not their images), or with what (a real weapon, not its simulation). Nor does he know whom he commands.

His first question after the revelation is whether the ships carried pilots, and his anguish is that he sent them to their deaths without knowing; they knew, Mazer answers, and went anyway (ch. 14). By Aristotle's criterion his subsequent anguish is not merely the sign of his involuntariness but its condition, since regret converts the non-voluntary into the involuntary. The paradox is precise: the more Ender grieves, the more innocent Aristotle makes him.

Aristotle also supplies the principle that relocates responsibility. One who is responsible for his own ignorance, as the drunkard is for the ignorance his drunkenness causes, is responsible for what he does in it (1113b30–1114a3). Ender did not cause his ignorance. The IF caused it, by design. On Aristotle's own reasoning, the culpability attaching to an act done in induced ignorance migrates to the one who induced it.

5.5 Intention Under a Description

Aquinas formulated the principle of double effect while defending killing in self-defense: "nihil prohibet unius actus esse duos effectus, quorum alter solum sit in intentione, alius vero sit praeter intentionem" (nothing prevents one act from having two effects, only one of which is intended while the other is beside the intention; *Summa Theologiae* II-II q.64 a.7). The doctrine is often invoked in Ender's defense, but it fits poorly. Ender intended to destroy the planet; he aimed at it. What he did not intend was the killing of living beings, because he did not believe there were any.

G. E. M. Anscombe's *Intention* (1957) supplies the more exact instrument: actions are intentional under a description. Ender acted intentionally under the description "destroying a simulated planet in contempt of my examiners" and unintentionally under the description "exterminating a species." A year earlier, Anscombe had published *Mr Truman's Degree* (1956), opposing Oxford's honorary degree for the president who ordered the atomic bombings, on the ground that choosing to kill the innocent as a means to one's end is murder. The two texts divide the novel's case between them. *Intention* relieves Ender, who did not act under the murderous description. *Mr Truman's Degree* condemns the IF, which chose the killing as a means and knew exactly under what description it acted.

Kant's good will, whose worth does not depend on what it accomplishes (*Groundwork*, 4:393–394), has been the defense's implicit theory, and Kessel's critique is aimed at it. Jean Piaget's *The Moral Judgment of the Child* (1932) offers an unexpected gloss on the dispute. Younger children, Piaget found, judge by objective consequences, rating the child who broke fifteen cups by accident naughtier than the one who broke a single cup while stealing jam; older children judge by in-

tention. The critical debate replays Piaget's experiment at cosmic scale: Ender broke a species by accident. The defense applies the mature, intentionalist criterion. Ender himself, in grief, judges himself by consequence, refusing the exculpation that developmental maturity would grant him. Chapter 9 argues that this apparent regression is in fact the recovery of an older and deeper moral logic.

5.6 Manufactured Innocence

The novel states the functional rationale of its deception with unusual clarity. When Ender accuses his teachers of having wanted Peter all along and tricked him into the killing, Graff answers that the trick was the whole point (ch. 14). The IF needed a commander with enough empathy to think like the enemy and enough compassion to make his subordinates work as one flawless machine, as flawless as the hive; yet a person with that compassion could never be the killer the war required. A commander capable of doing the thing knowingly would have lacked the understanding of the enemy that victory required, and a commander with that understanding would never have done it knowingly (chs. 14–15). I call this the *Wiggin theorem*: where victory requires an empathy that would forbid the act, the act requires ignorance. The theorem converts innocence from a moral property into an operational requirement. Mazer supplies its corollary: it had to be a child, because no decent adult who understands war can fight with a whole heart, and so the IF made sure that Ender did not know (ch. 14).

I therefore define *manufactured innocence* as an engineered epistemic state: the systematic production of nescience about particulars in an agent of maximal capacity, so that his acts will be at once maximally effective and minimally owned. Innocence so produced is not an excuse that follows the act but an instrument that precedes and enables it. The more innocent the instrument, the more lethal.

This reformulation transforms Kessel's charge without dismissing it. Kessel argued that Card rigs the moral universe to absolve his hero. The rigging is real, but the novel attributes it to the IF and shows it to the reader: the administrators' dialogues at the head of each chapter are the rigging made visible. The text is a study of how innocence can be produced, not merely a device that produces it. Kessel's objection survives at the level of affect, since the narration solicits identification with Ender and, through it, absolution. That residual tension between what the plot anatomizes and what the narration invites is real, and Chapter 9 treats it as a symptom of the apparatus rather than a flaw of the book.

The novel plants the formula of this innocence long before the IF uses it, and puts it in the mouth of the sadist. In the second chapter Peter, kneeling on his little brother's chest, tells him that he could crush him to death and then claim that he

had not known it would hurt, that they had only been playing (ch. 2). Moments later, having terrified both siblings with a threat, he explains that it was not a joke but a game, proof that he can make them believe anything and move them like puppets (ch. 2). The alibi of the unknowing player is first voiced as a murderer's excuse, and the art of making others believe a game is the first art the novel shows its villain practicing. The IF will make the excuse true and perfect the art.

5.7 Three Killings and the Compulsion to Repeat

The novel contains three killings, and they form a series. Ender kills Stilson in a schoolyard (ch. 1), Bonzo Madrid in a Battle School washroom (ch. 12), and the Formic species at its homeworld (ch. 14). Each is total. Each follows the doctrine that one must win all future fights in the present one. Each is concealed from Ender. The second follows a recorded decision not to intervene (ch. 12). At Command School Ender still believes that Bonzo was simply sent home, and when he likens the candidates who failed to Bonzo, Mazer's curt denial carries an irony visible only on rereading (ch. 14). Both human deaths surface after the war, when Ender, exercising his new rank, watches the videos of the fights and the photographs of the corpses shown at Graff's trial (ch. 15). The ages track the escalation: Stilson's killer is six, Bonzo's barely ten, the Formics' eleven. The scale increases by orders of magnitude, from a child to an adolescent to a species, and the jurisdictions change with it: a playground under no law, an institution that suspends its own, and the void between species where no law has ever run.

Freud described the compulsion to repeat as the return of an unmastered experience in an attempt to master it (*Beyond the Pleasure Principle*, 1920). The novel's structure is a repetition compulsion of escalating amplitude, and its narrative form is a geometric series. The apparatus does not merely permit the repetition; it requires it, since each killing certifies Ender's readiness for the next, and the concealment of each death preserves the innocence on which the next depends. Occultation is not a single deception practiced at the end. It is the medium in which Ender has lived since he was six.

6

CHAPTER SIX

The Wiggin Circuit

Empathy as Weapon and the Hermeneutics of Annihilation

6.1 The Paradox

In the lakeside conversation with Valentine that precedes his departure for Command School (ch. 13), Ender gives the novel's most cited account of his own genius. In paraphrase: at the moment he understands an enemy well enough to defeat him, he also loves him, because he cannot understand anyone so thoroughly without loving him as that being loves itself; and in that same moment of love, he destroys him. The passage turns on a correction. When Valentine supplies the expected word, that he beats his enemies, Ender rejects it: he destroys them, pursuing them to nonexistence so that they can never hurt him again (ch. 13). The difference between beating and destroying is the difference between Sun Tzu and the Stilson doctrine. The passage is usually read as a confession of anguish. It is also a theory of cognition, and a precise one. I call the cycle it describes the *Wiggin circuit*. Comprehension passes into identification, identification into love, love into prediction, and prediction into annihilation; the novel's last chapter adds two further arcs, from annihilation into grief and from grief into testimony.

6.2 From Sun Tzu to Schleiermacher: The Hermeneutics of Annihilation

The military tradition has always prized knowledge of the enemy, but it has rarely theorized that knowledge as love. The hermeneutic tradition supplies the missing term. Friedrich Schleiermacher's lectures on hermeneutics set interpretation the task of understanding an author first as well as, and then better than, he understood himself. Wilhelm Dilthey grounded the human sciences in *Verstehen*, understanding as the re-living (*Nacherleben*) of another's experience. Hans-Georg Gadamer's *Truth and Method* (1960) described understanding as a fusion of horizons. Ender's genius is hermeneutic in exactly these senses: he re-lives the adversary's experience, understands the adversary better than it understands itself, and fuses his horizon with its own.

What the hermeneutic tradition did not contemplate is the conversion of its maxim into a targeting principle. If I understand you better than you understand yourself, I can predict what you will do before you decide it, and I can be waiting there. Paul Ricoeur named Marx, Nietzsche, and Freud the masters of a hermeneutics of suspicion (*Freud and Philosophy*, 1965). Ender practices a *hermeneutics of annihilation*: interpretation whose consummation is the destruction of the interpreted. The hermeneutic circle closes as a firing solution.

6.3 Levinas and the Faceless Enemy

Emmanuel Levinas made the critique of comprehension the center of his ethics. In *Totality and Infinity* (1961) the face of the Other resists every attempt to grasp it, and in that resistance issues the command not to kill. Comprehension, the reduction of the Other to the categories of the Same, is for Levinas the root of violence; ontology, the philosophy of comprehension, is a philosophy of power. Ender's love is the love of comprehension, and it is lethal precisely in the way Levinas predicts. The Wiggin circuit demonstrates, from inside a war novel, that total understanding is a mode of possession and that possession can end in destruction.

The Formics complicate Levinas in a way that exposes the limit of his ethics. They have no face in his sense: insectile, collective, and speechless, they offer no visage whose resistance could command restraint. Levinas himself hesitated when asked whether an animal has a face, professing uncertainty about the snake, and his essay on Bobby, the dog who greeted prisoners in a German camp, admitted an animal only to the margins of ethical life. Jacques Derrida's *The Animal That Therefore I Am* (2006) pressed the objection that this anthropocentrism is no accident. The novel's ending answers it unexpectedly. *The Hive Queen*, the book Ender writes, gives the Formics a face that is not a visage but a narrative: an account of their life from within that makes their alterity legible as a claim. The faculty that

killed them, comprehension, is the faculty that restores their face. The Wiggin circuit is a pharmakon.

6.4 Dick's Inversion: Empathy as the Killer's Faculty

Philip K. Dick's *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968) makes empathy the criterion of the human. The Voigt-Kampff test detects androids by their failure of empathic response; Mercerism, the novel's religion, unites believers through an empathy box in which they share the sufferings of a saint who climbs a hill under a hail of stones. The bounty hunter's task requires suspending empathy toward beings defined by its absence. Card inverts the structure. In *Ender's Game* empathy is not what the killer must suspend but what makes him lethal, and the most empathetic child in the novel is the one who kills the most.

Contemporary psychology clarifies the inversion. Simon Baron-Cohen's distinction between cognitive empathy, the capacity to model another mind, and affective empathy, the capacity to share its feeling (*Zero Degrees of Empathy*, 2011), identifies the manipulator as possessing the first without the second. Paul Bloom's *Against Empathy* (2016) argued that empathy is a partial and innumerate moral guide; Fritz Breithaupt's *The Dark Sides of Empathy* (German 2017; English 2019) catalogued its uses in manipulation, vicarious appropriation, and sadism. Ender possesses both kinds of empathy in the highest degree. The novel's insight is that affective empathy is no brake on lethality when it is coupled to cognitive empathy and the will to win. The IF's concealment exists precisely to prevent affective empathy from becoming moral knowledge, that is, from completing itself as a refusal.

Graff's explanation after the battle confirms that both forms were cultivated by design. The IF needed cognitive empathy, to think like the enemy, and affective compassion, to bind the commander's subordinates into a single, hive-like instrument (ch. 14). Empathy was not an accident of Ender's character that the apparatus happened to exploit. It was the specification.

6.5 The Third: Peter, Valentine, and the Dialectical Child

The IF licensed Ender's birth because his siblings came close. Peter tested out for reasons that, the opening dialogue says, had nothing to do with ability; Valentine was conceived at the IF's request in the hope of a milder Peter and proved too mild; Ender was requisitioned to be, in his own summary, half of each (chs. 1, 3). Ender is bred as their synthesis. In the terms of the preceding section, Peter embodies cognitive empathy in the service of domination; the novel's emblem is the squirrel Valentine once found half-skinned and staked to the ground by its paws, the record of a boy who studies suffering without sharing it (ch. 9). Valentine embodies affective empathy in the service of protection, a figure of what Carol Gilligan's *In a Different Voice* (1982) would call an ethic of care. Ender is their fusion. In Hegel's vocabulary he is their *Aufhebung*, the synthesis that cancels, preserves, and elevates both moments at once. The IF performs with a population license what Hegel's Spirit performs with history: it breeds the dialectic.

The psychoanalytic traditions describe the same structure from within. Melanie Klein's paranoid-schizoid position splits the world into wholly good and wholly bad objects; the depressive position integrates them, recognizes that the loved and the hated object are one, and gives rise to guilt and to the impulse to repair ("Love, Guilt and Reparation," 1937). Ender's world begins split: Valentine all good, Peter and the buggers all bad. The xenocide forces integration, since the enemy proves to be an object of love and Ender proves to have done what Peter would do. His subsequent life is Kleinian reparation in the most literal form, the restoration of the destroyed object. C. G. Jung would read Peter as Ender's shadow and Valentine as his anima, the Fantasy Game as a technology of active imagination, and the Hive Queen's communication through Ender's own dream-images as the collective unconscious made literal as a collective consciousness.

René Girard supplies the most exact reading of the novel's central image of doubling. In *Violence and the Sacred* (1972), Girard describes the monstrous double, the hallucinatory figure that appears at the height of mimetic crisis, when rivals have become indistinguishable. At the End of the World in the Fantasy Game, Ender looks into a mirror and sees not his own face but Peter's, bloodied and serpentine. The scene is the monstrous double in pure form. Ender answers it with denial and then dread: the game, he tells himself, lies; he is not his brother and harbors no murderous intent; and beneath the denial lies the fear that he is wrong (ch. 8). The administrators, for their part, admit that the End of the World was never programmed and that the computer had taken no one there before (ch. 9); the coda will show the same landscape rebuilt by the queens from images in Ender's mind. The scene announces the novel's darkest proposition: the Third is the place where de-

stroyer and preserver become indistinguishable. Girard's anthropology returns in Chapter 9, where the double becomes the scapegoat. The biblical frame is already present. Seth, the third son, was given "instead of Abel, whom Cain slew" (Genesis 4:25). Ender is the appointed seed born into a household whose Cain promised to kill him, and the appointed seed becomes, in the end, his brother's equal in killing.

6.6 Knowing According to the Flesh

The theological meaning of the circuit was anticipated in Chapter 2. Alma 7:11–12 describes an atonement accomplished through the acquisition of a knowledge of others "according to the flesh," and the Sermon on the Mount commands, "Love your enemies" (Matthew 5:44). The Wiggin circuit literalizes the commandment and inverts its function: Ender loves his enemies, and his love is the instrument of their destruction. Augustine's maxim *dilige, et quod vis fac* (love, and do what you will; *Homilies on the First Epistle of John* 7.8) assumed that love would sanctify every act it governs. Ender's case is the counterexample, in which love governs every act and makes every act lethal.

Yet the circuit does not end at annihilation. Its final arcs, grief and testimony, return the faculty to its theological vocation. The understanding that targeted the enemy turns, after the war, to succor the dead. Ender names the turn himself. He tells Valentine that he will go to the colony world because he knows the buggers better than anyone alive, and that having stolen their future, he can begin to repay them only by learning from their past (ch. 15). Before the pupal queen he discovers the circuit's final use: weeping her people's grief, he tells her that if she could make humans feel what she makes him feel, they might forgive her people (ch. 15). The book he then writes is that transmission. The comprehension that killed is the comprehension that atones, and the novel's moral structure depends on that identity.

7

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Locus of Mind

Xenology, Mereological Misrecognition, and the Philology of the Enemy

7.1 The Casus Belli as Category Error

The final chapter discloses the origin of the war, and it is a philosophical error rather than a political one. Through the images she places in Ender's mind, the pupal queen conveys her people's history (ch. 15). The Formics are a hive in which individual bodies are extensions of a queen's mind. When they first encountered humans, they found no queen and perceived no mind. They had believed themselves the only thinking beings in the universe and never imagined that thought could arise in solitary animals unable to share one another's dreams; individual humans seemed to them as workers seem, bodies whose loss carries no moral weight. They did not mean to murder, the queen conveys, and once they understood, they never came again (ch. 15). Even their defeat was without rage. Reliving through the queen's many eyes the first battle he fought, Ender feels in her not pain or fear but sadness and resignation, and her conviction that humanity had not forgiven them (ch. 15). Humanity, for its part, saw insects: swarming, mindless bodies driven by monstrous queens. Each species misidentified the unit of personhood in the other. The scale of the consequence is given once, in Ender's thought during Graff's trial: some ten billion beings (ch. 15), destroyed at a stroke by the fleet under Ender's command, because every queen of every colony had gathered on the homeworld (ch. 14).

I call this error *mereological misrecognition*: the failure to locate the bearer of mind across a difference in the part–whole organization of minds. It is the casus belli of the Formic War and the novel's most original contribution to the philoso-

phy of other minds. The classical problem asks whether another being has a mind. The novel asks a prior question: where, in another kind of being, a mind is located, and at what scale.

7.2 Gavagai, the Mill, and Aunt Hillary

W. V. O. Quine's thought experiment of radical translation (*Word and Object*, 1960, ch. 2) imagines a linguist who hears a native say "gavagai" as a rabbit runs past and cannot determine from behavior alone whether the word refers to rabbits, to temporal stages of rabbits, or to undetached rabbit parts. The inscrutability of reference Quine discovered at the level of semantics becomes, in the novel, a casus belli at the level of moral ontology. Confronted with a human soldier, the Formics chose "undetached part"; confronted with a Formic worker, humanity chose "insect." Neither could determine from behavior alone what kind of whole it faced.

Leibniz's mill (*Monadology*, 1714, §17) supplies the image. Were a thinking machine enlarged to the size of a mill so that one could walk inside it, one would find only parts pushing one another, never anything that explains perception. Each species walked inside the other's mill and found only parts. Douglas Hofstadter's dialogue "Prelude . . . Ant Fugue" in *Gödel, Escher, Bach* (1979) imagines the inverse case: Aunt Hillary, an ant colony that is a conscious interlocutor though no single ant is conscious, with whom an anteater converses as with a friend. The entomological background runs from William Morton Wheeler's essay "The Ant-Colony as an Organism" (1911) through E. O. Wilson's *The Insect Societies* (1971) to Bert Hölldobler and Wilson's *The Superorganism* (2009). Card gives the superorganism a queen-centered mind and asks Hofstadter's question in a military key: what does it take to recognize a colony as someone?

Thomas Nagel's "What Is It Like to Be a Bat?" (1974) argued that the subjective character of experience is inaccessible from outside the point of view that has it. Wittgenstein observed that if a lion could speak, we could not understand him. Donald Davidson's "On the Very Idea of a Conceptual Scheme" (1974) argued, by contrast, that we can identify something as a language only if it is largely translatable, so that interpretation must begin with charity, the presumption of shared truth. Formics and humans failed Davidson's precondition in both directions. Formic communication is telepathic and wordless; human communication is spoken. Each species failed to recognize the other's medium as communication at all, and charity could not begin, because neither recognized the other as someone to interpret. The war's irony runs deeper still. To defeat a hive, the IF sought a commander who could make his human subordinates work as a single flawless ma-

chine, as flawless as the enemy (ch. 14). Humanity fought the superorganism by becoming one.

7.3 Personhood Without Morphology: Valladolid and the Speaker's Hierarchy

The historical precedent for the novel's question is the debate at Valladolid (1550–1551), in which Juan Ginés de Sepúlveda, invoking Aristotle's doctrine of natural slavery, argued for the subjugation of the peoples of the Americas, and Bartolomé de las Casas argued for their full rationality and against the conquest's violence. A decade earlier Francisco de Vitoria's lectures *De Indis* (1539) had concluded that the inhabitants of the Americas held true dominion over their lands and could not be dispossessed on the ground of unbelief. Card himself conceived xenocide on the Columbian template: *Pastwatch: The Redemption of Christopher Columbus* (1996) imagines a future that intervenes in history to prevent the destruction of the Americas.

The sequel to *Ender's Game* formalizes the Valladolid question in its hierarchy of foreignness, which distinguishes the stranger from one's own world, the human stranger from another world, the alien recognized as a person (*raman*), and the alien with whom no dialogue is possible (*varelse*) (*Speaker for the Dead*, 1986). The decisive feature of the taxonomy is that *varelse* is a relational category, defined by the impossibility of dialogue, and an impossibility of dialogue may lie in the interpreter rather than the interpreted. In *Ender's Game* the Formics are treated as *varelse* until the Speaker's book makes them *raman*. The reclassification is not a discovery about their morphology, which is unchanged, but about the location of their minds. Kant's grounding of moral status in rational nature rather than species (Chapter 3) here receives its literary demonstration.

7.4 The Philology of the Slur

In the novel itself the enemy has only one name, and it is a slur: the 1985 text calls them nothing but buggers, and the taxonomic name enters the cycle only with later volumes and the 2013 film. Across the cycle, the enemy bears two names. The formal name, *Formic*, derives from the Latin *formica*, ant; it is the language of taxonomy. The common name, *bugger*, has a darker genealogy. English inherited it from the Old French *bougre*, from the medieval Latin *Bulgarus*, "Bulgarian," a name applied to the Bogomil heretics of the Balkans and then to heretics generally, who were routinely accused of sodomy; the word's sexual sense in English descends from that accusation. The slur thus sediments three successive regimes of othering: religious, sexual, and zoological. The double naming encodes the two great registers of modern othering, classification and abjection. This study registers the sedimentation without imputing intention to it. The point is that the novel's dehumanizing vocabulary carries the history of dehumanization inside it, and that within the novel the dignity of a neutral name is never granted. The enemy acquires a voice before it acquires a name: it first speaks in its own person in the book Ender writes for it.

The sexual sense needs more precision than this study first gave it. English law made buggery a capital crime under Henry VIII in 1533 and kept the death penalty for it until 1861; the last executions for it in England took place in 1835. The word the novel gives its enemy is thus the name of an offense for which the English state hanged men, and long a common term of abuse for men accused of sex with men. Its use as the species' only name sits beside its author's later public record on homosexuality, set out in Chapter 10. The juxtaposition is this study's: it is an observation about the vocabulary, not a claim about what Card intended in 1977 or 1985. The novel's human world is saturated with slurs of its own. Ender's schoolmates taunt him as a Third (ch. 1), and Battle School students call Rat Army, whose commander is Jewish, by the antisemitic slur *kike*, in the same passage that records the myth of Jewish generalship (ch. 8). The vocabulary of extermination aimed at the aliens is continuous with the vocabulary of contempt that humans aim at one another.

That history is one of insectification. Nazi propaganda called Jews vermin (*Ungeziefer*); in 1994 Radio Télévision Libre des Mille Collines, the broadcaster of the Hutu Power movement, called Tutsi cockroaches (*inyenzi*). The words did their work. The Nazi state and its collaborators murdered some six million European Jews; Hutu Power militias and soldiers, and the civilians they mobilized, murdered between half a million and eight hundred thousand people, most of them Tutsi, in about a hundred days. David Livingstone Smith's *Less Than Human* (2011) traces the

recurrence of such figures as the preparatory grammar of extermination. Samuel R. Delany observed that science fiction literalizes what other fiction leaves figurative, so that a sentence like "her world exploded" may in science fiction mean exactly what it says ("About 5,750 Words," 1969). Card literalizes the genocidal metaphor. His enemy really is insectile, and Graff insists, with a scientist's care, that the resemblance is no accident (ch. 13).

The literalization is the novel's most rigorous moral experiment. Historical genocides have depended on a lie, the description of human beings as vermin. Card subtracts the lie and asks whether extermination becomes permissible when the insect description is true. The answer delivered through the Speaker is that it does not, because morphology was never the question; mind was. I call this the *subtraction of the alibi*. By making the dehumanizing metaphor literally true, the novel shows that the metaphor was never the real ground of the crime, and that its truth would not have justified it.

7.5 Kafka's Household

Franz Kafka's *The Metamorphosis* (1915) opens with Gregor Samsa transformed into a monstrous vermin (*ungeheueres Ungeziefer*) and ends, after his death, with his family's relief: parents and daughter ride a tram into the countryside, and the parents notice that Grete has blossomed into a young woman. The aftermath of the xenocide has the same shape. Freed of its insect, the human household flourishes. Graff, now Minister of Colonization, remarks how convenient it is that the enemy's worlds are already fertile and furnished with dwellings and industry, their makers all dead, and he announces that the population limits will be repealed (ch. 15). The law that made Ender a stigmatized Third is abolished by the room his act has made. Kafka's family writes no account of Gregor's inner life. The Speaker writes exactly that account. *The Hive Queen* is the book Gregor's family never wrote: the vermin's life told from within by the one who killed it.

7.6 Lem's Objection

Stanisław Lem's xenology poses the strongest objection to Card's. In *Solaris* and *Fiasco* the alien may be inaccessible in principle, and the attempt to understand it on human terms is itself the source of catastrophe. Card's answer is hermeneutically optimistic: the Hive Queen can be understood, and understood by the very empath who destroyed her. The failure in *Ender's Game* is temporal, not ontological. Card's xenology is hermeneutically optimistic and morally tragic; Lem's is hermeneutically tragic and morally ironic. The positions are complementary rather than contradictory. Lem shows what happens when understanding is impossible; Card shows what happens when it is possible and arrives too late.

7.7 Synthesis

Mereological misrecognition names a category of moral failure that the philosophy of other minds has largely neglected: the failure not to attribute mind but to locate it. The unit of moral considerability is not given by morphology or by the boundaries of the organism; it must be interpreted, and war follows when interpretive charity fails at the level of the unit. The category has growing contemporary purchase: in the theory of group agency (Christian List and Philip Pettit, *Group Agency*, 2011); in debates over corporate moral responsibility; in the study of distributed animal cognition, such as the octopus whose arms carry much of its nervous system (Peter Godfrey-Smith, *Other Minds*, 2016); and in the question of which unit of an artificial system, the model, the instance, or the deployment, would bear whatever moral standing such systems may come to have. *Ender's Game* stages the first war fought over a mereological mistake, and it ends with that mistake transfigured. The book Ender writes in the queen's voice welcomes the human colonists as adopted daughters and tells them that, where the queens can no longer act, they are now the queens' hands (ch. 15). The error that began the war, the perception of humans as a hive's workers, returns at the end as an act of adoption. Philosophy has reason to expect that it will not be the last such question it must face.

8

CHAPTER EIGHT

The Ludic Polity

Play, the Magic Circle, and Harvested Transgression

8.1 Four Theories of Play

Johan Huizinga's *Homo Ludens* (1938) defined play as a free activity standing consciously outside ordinary life, absorbing yet not serious, bounded in time and space by rules, and enclosed in a magic circle. Huizinga found the play-form in archaic war itself, and he distinguished two offenders against the game: the cheat, who pretends to respect the rules while breaking them and so preserves the play-world, and the spoilsport, who shatters the play-world by refusing it and is punished more severely. Roger Caillois's *Man, Play and Games* (1958) classified games by four impulses, *agon* (competition), *alea* (chance), *mimicry* (simulation), and *ilinx* (vertigo), and described the corruption of each when the boundary with ordinary life is breached. Bernard Suits's *The Grasshopper* (1978) defined game-playing as "the voluntary attempt to overcome unnecessary obstacles," adding the requirement of a lusory attitude in which the rules are accepted because they make the activity possible. D. W. Winnicott's *Playing and Reality* (1971) located play in a potential space between inner and outer reality, where the true self comes into being, and held that compliance destroys it.

Each theory illuminates the Battle School by being violated in it. Huizinga's magic circle is breached; Caillois's corruption is institutionalized; Suits's obstacles are necessary rather than unnecessary, and the attitude toward them is not voluntary; Winnicott's potential space is colonized by compliance. The Battle School is a polity in which play is not the antithesis of war but its medium.

8.2 The Battle Room: Agon Under Vertigo

The Battle Room joins *agon* to *ilinx*: armies compete under the vertigo of weightlessness. Caillois's combinatorics treats this pairing as inherently unstable, since vertigo dissolves the controlled conditions that competition requires. The Battle Room institutionalizes the unstable pairing, and Ender's first genius is to stabilize it. Where other commanders treat the room as a corridor with a floor and a ceiling inherited from the gravitational world, Ender founds a new orientation.

8.3 A Phenomenology of Orientation

The novel's most famous formula, "the enemy's gate is down," is usually read as a tactical insight. It is better read as a phenomenological act. Maurice Merleau-Ponty's *Phenomenology of Perception* (1945) used George Stratton's experiment with inverting lenses, and Max Wertheimer's with a tilted mirror, to show that up and down are not given in the retinal image but constituted by the body's practical hold on its world: after a period of disorientation, the subject's spatial level re-anchors itself around its possibilities of action. Edmund Husserl's fragment of 1934 on the spatiality of nature argued that the Earth is experienced not as a body in motion but as the original ground (*Boden*), the ark relative to which motion and rest are first constituted.

The children of the Battle School have lost the Earth-ground. Ender's dictum founds a ground by fiat, and it founds it on the enemy. Down is the direction of falling and of rest, the direction toward which a body orients itself when it seeks a place to stand; Ender identifies it with the enemy's gate. The enemy becomes the Earth. Orientation is re-anchored to the adversary, and the body's spatial level is reorganized around the project of reaching him. This is the Wiggin circuit expressed in the grammar of space: the enemy is the one toward whom I fall.

The tactical correlates complete the phenomenology. Ender's soldiers advance feet-first, freezing their own legs so that their limbs become shields; the body schema is reconfigured so that parts of the lived body become instruments and objects. John Boyd placed orientation at the center of his decision cycle, as the phase in which a combatant's whole inheritance of culture and experience is brought to bear and in which advantage is won by reorienting faster than the opponent. Edwin Abbott's *Flatland* (1884) imagined the higher dimension as an orientation unavailable to those not yet lifted into it. Ender's genius is the capacity to re-found the up and the down of a world, and it is the phenomenological condition of everything he later does.

The formula has a history in the novel, and its history is the argument. It first appears in a private list of lessons Ender draws up after his earliest battles in Sala-

mander Army, beside the discovery that frozen legs make a shield (ch. 7). He teaches it to Dragon Army as a doctrine of erased gravity, in which feet point toward the enemy's gate and up is toward one's own (ch. 10). And it returns at the climax. Facing the enemy's homeworld, Ender recalls his last Battle School game, which he won by ignoring the enemy and his own losses and moving against the gate; Bean, remembering the same game, repeats the formula over the headset; and Ender resolves to move against the planet itself (ch. 14). The planet becomes the gate. The phenomenology of orientation is not a prelude to the xenocide. It is its form.

8.4 The Giant's Drink and the No-Win Scenario

In the Fantasy Game a giant offers Ender two drinks and promises a journey to Fairyland for the right one; every choice kills him, and he concludes that the game is rigged (ch. 6). The scenario cannot be won by its rules. After repeated deaths, Ender refuses the rules: he attacks the giant, burrows into his eye, and kills him, and the game opens onto the lands beyond. The administrators read the episode as a diagnostic of how the child meets an unwinnable test, and they are disturbed and gratified at once. One of them calls the Giant's Drink the most perverted part of the game and asks whether a boy who goes for the eye is the one to command the fleets (ch. 7).

The episode has a famous contemporary in the Kobayashi Maru of *Star Trek II: The Wrath of Khan* (1982), a training simulation designed to have no winning outcome, which James Kirk defeated by reprogramming it. Both stories make the refusal of the no-win scenario a mark of command genius. Card's version adds two things. First, the refusal is violent: Kirk cheats, but Ender kills. Second, the test is a pharmakon in the literal sense, two cups, both poison. Aristotle's example of the one who gives a drink to save and kills instead (Chapter 5) finds its fairy-tale form here. The Giant's Drink is the novel's emblem of the undecidable remedy, and it is the first time Ender meets a pharmakon by refusing to drink.

8.5 Harvested Transgression

Ender's career is a sequence of transgressions. He kills the giant. He overturns the conventions of the Battle Room with formations and tactics its rules never anticipated. In his final Battle School engagement, against two armies at once, he ends the game by executing its formal victory condition against an undefeated enemy, exposing the rules as arbitrary. At Command School, intending to be dismissed, he turns the Little Doctor on the enemy's planet in contempt of his examiners. Each transgression is, from the IF's point of view, the desired result, and the administrators say so in advance: the boy must be isolated enough to stay creative, lest he adopt the system and be lost to it (ch. 4). The institution is designed so that its subject's refusals of its rules are precisely what it seeks. The final transgression even breaks a taboo the institution itself had taught. Mazer had told Ender that the Little Doctor could never be used on a planet (ch. 14); Ender, modeling his last move on his last Battle School game, reasons that breaking this rule will end his career, that he will never have to play again, and that this is victory (ch. 14).

I call this design *harvested transgression*. Its pedagogical ancestor is Rousseau's captive will (Chapter 1), in which freedom is staged so that the child's spontaneity serves the tutor's plan. Its political analogues are Herbert Marcuse's analyses of repressive tolerance (1965) and repressive desublimation (*One-Dimensional Man*, 1964), in which a system absorbs and neutralizes the energies of opposition, and Foucault's account in *Discipline and Punish* of a carceral system that produces delinquency as a useful and governable illegality. The novel adds the case in which transgression is not merely absorbed but harvested: converted into the system's highest yield.

Huizinga's typology makes the final turn visible. Ender's last act at Command School is a spoilsport's act, a refusal meant to shatter the play-world. But the play-world was built to be shattered. The spoilsport's gesture, which in Huizinga's account destroys the game, is here the game's intended consummation. The deepest obedience the apparatus could obtain from Ender took the form of his deepest defiance.

8.6 The Game as Empire

The cultural afterlife of this structure is extensive. *The Last Starfighter* (1984) imagined an arcade cabinet that recruits a teenager for an interstellar war. *WarGames* (1983) concluded of a nuclear simulation that the only winning move is not to play; *Ender's Game* concludes that the only winning move is to destroy the game, and the world with it. Banks's Azad (Chapter 4) is a game that is an empire. The United States Army released *America's Army* (2002) as an instrument of recruitment, and James Der Derian's *Virtuous War* (2001) described a military-industrial-media-entertainment network in which war is designed, rehearsed, and sold through the same media. In this landscape the magic circle is no longer a boundary separating play from life. It is a membrane across which life is extracted from play.

8.7 Synthesis

The ludic analysis yields the third operation of pharmakotic sovereignty: *execution*, the enactment of the sovereign decision as a move in a game. The decision on the exception, which Schmitt reserved to the sovereign, is executed by a child at play. Execution through play completes the work of occultation, because the form of play supplies the false description under which the act is performed. It also anticipates disclamation, because a move in a game is, by the conventions of games, no one's crime. Part III asks what becomes of the guilt that the game was designed to make no one's.

PART

III

Synthesis

Toward a Theory of Pharmakotic Sovereignty

9

CHAPTER NINE

Pharmakon and Pharmakos

Toward a Theory of Pharmakotic Sovereignty

9.1 The Pharmacy of the Text

In "Plato's Pharmacy" (1968; collected in *Dissemination*, 1972), Jacques Derrida read Socrates' myth of Theuth in the *Phaedrus* (274e–275b), in which writing is offered to King Thamus as a *pharmakon* for memory and rejected as a drug that will produce forgetfulness. Derrida showed that the word's double sense, remedy and poison, cannot be resolved by translation, and that its undecidability organizes Plato's text. He also noted a term absent from the dialogue but present in its lexical family: the *pharmakos*, the human scapegoat whom Greek cities expelled or killed in times of crisis, and whose expulsion purified the community.

Ender's Game is a pharmacy, and its pharmaka are four. The Giant's Drink offers two cups, both lethal: the pharmakon as no-win (Chapter 8). The noble lie of the game is a remedy that spares the child knowledge and a poison that makes him a xenocide (Chapter 5). The Little Doctor, the Molecular Detachment Device, bears a physician's name by way of an institutional joke (Chapter 3) and cures humanity by killing a species. And *The Hive Queen*, the book Ender writes, is writing in the Phaedran sense: a remedy for the memory of the dead and a poison to the name of the one who wrote it. The text names its own pharmakon in the vernacular of the fleet, a lexical fact whose implications have not, so far as I know, been drawn out. Its pharmakos is Ender.

9.2 The Two Goats

The Levitical rite of the Day of Atonement prescribes two goats (Leviticus 16). Lots are cast. One goat is "for the LORD" and is slain as a sin offering. Upon the head of the other the high priest lays both hands and confesses "all the iniquities of the children of Israel"; the goat is then sent into the wilderness, and "the goat shall bear upon him all their iniquities unto a land not inhabited" (16:21–22).

The terminal configuration of *Ender's Game* reproduces the Levitical diptych. The Formics are the goat that is slain. Ender is the goat that is sent away, bearing the iniquity of the people into a land not inhabited: the colony worlds, uninhabited because emptied of the Formics who had prepared them. And the confession that loads the people's sin is performed by himself. Writing as the Speaker for the Dead, Ender composes *The Hive Queen*, which teaches humanity to grieve what it did. The novel keeps the author hidden: the book is signed with a title rather than a name, no one knows or wishes to know who the first Speaker was, and Valentine publishes the text at the end of her history without attribution (ch. 15). The transfer of guilt onto the name therefore begins inside the novel and is completed outside it. It begins at Graff's trial, where the prosecution, not daring to charge the boy, tries to make him appear mentally ill, morally depraved, and criminally insane (ch. 15). It is completed in the sequel, set some three thousand years later, in which "Ender" has become a byword for xenocide while the Speaker's book has become scripture (*Speaker for the Dead*, 1986). He is high priest and goat at once, distinguished only by a pseudonym.

This is the novel's structural innovation and the literary limit-case of the scapegoat figure: a scapegoat who performs his own scapegoating, possible only because pseudonymity divides him into the priest who confesses and the animal who bears. The principle the rite enacts has its New Testament statement in the counsel of the high priest Caiaphas, "that it is expedient for us, that one man should die for the people, and that the whole nation perish not" (John 11:50). Graff's logic is Caiaphas's. The novel's variation is that the one man does not die. He is made to bear the guilt alive, and his nation is saved while another nation perishes.

9.3 Girard's Mechanism and Its Revelation

René Girard's anthropology (*Violence and the Sacred*, 1972; *Things Hidden Since the Foundation of the World*, 1978; *The Scapegoat*, 1982) describes the founding mechanism of human culture. Mimetic rivalry escalates into a crisis in which rivals become doubles; the community discharges its violence upon a single victim, unanimously; the victim's death restores order; and the victim is retrospectively sacralized. Myths conceal the mechanism by representing the victim as guilty. The Gospels, for Girard, reveal it by proclaiming the victim's innocence.

The novel enacts the mechanism with a precision that tests Girard's own claims. The mimetic crisis is terrestrial: Hegemony against Warsaw Pact and, inside the Wiggin household, Peter against everyone. The Formic threat discharges that rivalry outward, producing human unanimity against a single collective victim. The xenocide restores order, but only briefly. Because the victim was external, the sacrifice cannot be repeated, and the crisis returns at once as the League War (ch. 15). Then comes the revelation. *The Hive Queen* proclaims the victim's innocence; it is, in Girard's precise sense, a gospel. But the revelation does not abolish the mechanism. It redirects it. The innocence of the Formics is established, and the scapegoat function migrates onto Ender: inside the novel through a trial that attacks him by proxy, and in the sequel through a name that has become a curse.

The novel thus documents a paradox Girard approached in his late work (*I See Satan Fall Like Lightning*, 1999), in which the modern concern for victims itself becomes a source of persecution. The revelation of the victim's innocence produces a second-order scapegoat, the one held responsible for the victim. Ender is that scapegoat, and the critical history of the novel, in which he has been tried again and again, is its continuation.

9.4 Neither Innocent Nor Guilty

Northrop Frye's *Anatomy of Criticism* (1957) identifies the *pharmakos* as the typical victim of the ironic mode, a figure "neither innocent nor guilty": innocent in that what befalls him far exceeds anything he has done, guilty in that he belongs to a guilty society or lives in a world where such injustice is part of the order of things. Frye's formula dissolves the impasse with which this dissertation began. Radford and Kessel argue that Ender is guilty, or that the novel improperly declares him innocent; Card argues that he is innocent. The pharmakos is constructed precisely to exceed that binary. The critical debate has been conducted in the forensic categories the figure is designed to defeat.

9.5 Pollution Without Guilt

Archaic Greek law and religion possessed what the forensic model lacks: a category for the killer who is innocent and yet polluted. Robert Parker's *Miasma* (1983) reconstructs the logic by which blood shed, even unintentionally, defiles the shedder and requires purification. The tradition generated case law startlingly close to the novel's. Plutarch relays a story that Pericles and Protagoras spent an entire day debating whether, when an athlete accidentally killed a man with a javelin at the games, the blame by the strictest reasoning lay with the javelin, with the thrower, or with the officials who managed the contest (*Life of Pericles* 36). Antiphon's Second Tetralogy is a set of model speeches on a youth killed by a javelin in the gymnasium, in which the defense argues that the victim, having run into the javelin's path, brought about his own death.

The three candidates of Plutarch's anecdote are the three candidates of the novel: the instrument (the Little Doctor), the thrower (Ender), and the organizers of the games (the IF). The Antiphontic defense, that the victim ran into the path of the throw, is the defense of the Third Invasion: the Formics came first.

Plato's *Laws* codifies the distinctions. One who kills unintentionally in athletic contests or military exercises is to be purified according to the law from Delphi and is then clean; one who unintentionally kills a free person in other circumstances must also be purified and must leave his country for a year (865a–866a). Ender's case lies exactly on the boundary between these provisions. He killed during what he took to be a military exercise, and the deaths of his own pilots, who knew what the maneuvers were and flew them anyway (ch. 14), fall under the first provision. For the Formics, enemies in war, Greek law would have imposed nothing at all. Yet Ender imposes on himself the exile reserved for the unintentional killer of a fellow citizen, and he imposes it for life. The form of his penance is itself an act of recognition. By exiling himself as one exiles the killer of a citizen, he enfranchises the dead.

Sophocles' *Oedipus at Colonus* is the tragedy of this condition. The old, blind Oedipus insists that his deeds were suffered rather than done, *peponthota mallon ē dedrakota* (266–267), and argues at length that one cannot justly be blamed for what one did unknowing (960–999). He is legally innocent and ritually polluted, and his body becomes a protective blessing for the city that receives it. Ender's arc ends in the same configuration. No court tries him; Graff is the one tried. He is barred from his home. And he carries with him a sacred remainder, the pupal queen, who will be a blessing to the world that receives her. The book he writes in her voice already pronounces that blessing over the emptied worlds, calling on their trees to blossom and their planets to be fertile for the human colonists (ch. 15).

Bernard Williams gave this ancient wisdom its modern philosophical form. In "Moral Luck" (1976) he described agent-regret, the distinctive response of the lorry driver who, through no fault of his own, runs over a child: we would think less of him if he felt only what a spectator feels. Agent-regret is appropriate even in the absence of culpability, and in *Shame and Necessity* (1993) Williams argued that the Greeks understood better than the moderns that what one has done in ignorance remains one's own deed. Thomas Nagel's companion essay of the same title (1976) classified the forms of moral luck, among them resultant luck, in which the moral character of an act depends on outcomes beyond the agent's control, and circumstantial luck, in which it depends on the situation the agent happens to face. Ender is the purest literary case of both: the same move in a game is either nothing or xenocide, depending on facts he could not know. Susan Wolf has described the virtue of taking responsibility for more than one's fault ("The Moral of Moral Luck," 2001). That virtue is Ender's, and the novel's last exchange makes it constitutive of his identity. When Ender admits that he is almost happy where he is and Valentine asks why, then, he will not stay, he answers that he has lived too long with pain to know who he would be without it (ch. 15).

The conclusion matters for the critical debate. The novel's moral universe is not the Kantian universe of pure intention that Kessel attacks and Card's apologetics presuppose. It is closer to the archaic and Williamsian universe in which innocence and pollution coexist, and in which the fitting response to a deed that is one's own without being one's fault is neither exculpation nor condemnation but the assumption of a burden. On this point the novel is wiser than the terms in which it has usually been defended.

9.6 Pharmakotic Sovereignty: A Formal Statement

Schmitt defined the sovereign as the one who decides on the exception (*Political Theology*, 1922). Giorgio Agamben's *Homo Sacer* (1995) recovered from Roman law the figure of one who may be killed without the killing counting as homicide and who cannot be sacrificed, and argued that sovereign power is constituted by its relation to such bare life. The Formics are *homines sacri* in the strict sense: killable without homicide, because not human, and not sacrificed, because not offered. The Speaker's book alters their status retroactively, converting their deaths into a loss and so, in a second sense of the word, into something sacred. Foucault's account of biopower adds the decisive modern inflection: when power is exercised at the level of life, species, and population, wars are waged in the name of the survival of all, and mass killing comes to be justified as a necessity of life (*The History of Sexuality*, vol. 1, 1976). A war between species is the purest fiction of biopolitical war, and Ender, conceived under a state license for the state's survival, is its purest biopolitical subject.

On these foundations I propose the following definition. *Pharmakotic sovereignty* is the configuration in which a sovereign power, deciding on an exception of existential scope, executes its decision through an instrument it has rendered innocent, so that the decision is enacted without being owned and its guilt becomes transferable. It consists of six operations:

1. **Consecration**: the selection and separation of the instrument (the licensed birth, the removal at six; foreordination secularized; Chapters 1–2).
2. **Occultation**: the production of nescience about the particulars of the act (the inverted cave; manufactured innocence; Chapter 5).
3. **Execution**: the enactment of the sovereign decision as play (the final examination; harvested transgression; Chapter 8).
4. **Disclamation**: the declaration that the act is no one's, its responsibility distributed across bureaucracy, instrument, and enemy (the court-martial and its acquittal; Chapter 10).
5. **Transference**: the loading of residual guilt onto the instrument and his expulsion with it (the Levitical goat; the Girardian scapegoat; this chapter).
6. **Testimony**: the instrument's return as witness, supplying the polity with the moral narrative of its crime, a narrative that both reabsorbs the crime and exceeds the apparatus (the Speaker; Chapter 11).

The six operations form a cycle, and the cycle has an exit. Testimony is reabsorbed as the polity's moral narrative, renewing the conditions of consecration for

the next exception; but testimony also institutes a practice of truth the apparatus cannot govern. Figure 1 draws the cycle and its exit.

FIGURE 1

The decision passes through an innocent and returns as testimony

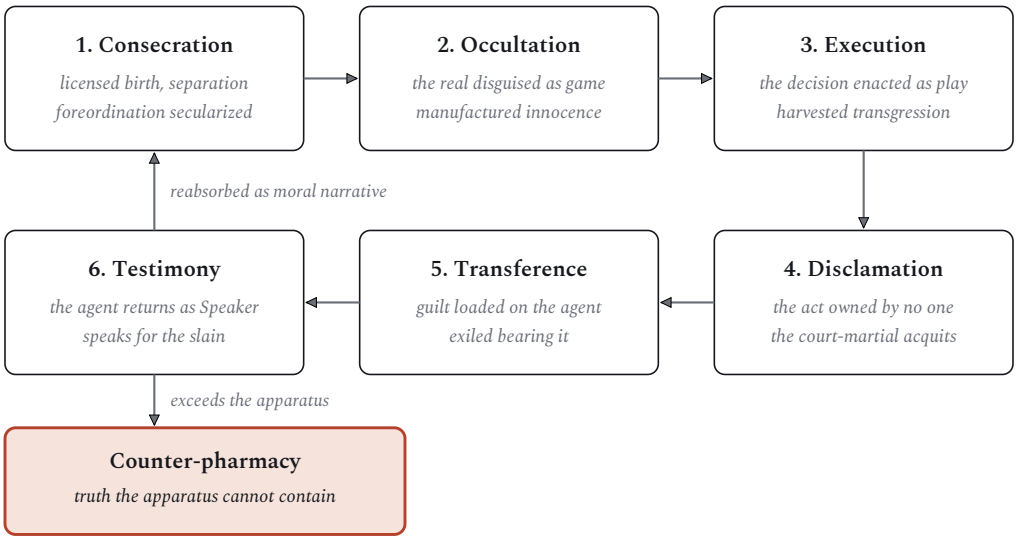


Figure 1. Read clockwise from the top left: the sovereign decision passes through an engineered innocent and returns as testimony, which the polity either reabsorbs as its moral narrative or cannot contain.

9.7 What the Theory Explains

The theory explains, first, the novel's double affect, its capacity to solicit both absolution and horror. The apparatus produces both. Operations one through three manufacture the innocence the reader feels; operations four and five produce the guilt the reader also feels. The reader experiences the apparatus from inside, as Ender does.

It explains, second, the shape of the critical controversy. Card's defense speaks from the second operation: Ender did not know. Kessel's prosecution speaks from the fifth: guilt must land somewhere, and a narrative that refuses to let it land on its hero is suspect. Both positions are moments internal to the apparatus. The controversy is not a dispute about the ritual; it is the ritual's afterlife, conducted in criticism.

It explains, third, why the novel cannot end with victory. Victory completes only the third operation. The novel's form requires the fourth, fifth, and sixth, because the apparatus is incomplete until its guilt has been disclaimed, transferred, and re-

turned as testimony. The coda that some readers have taken for a sentimental appendix is the apparatus completing itself and, in its last movement, escaping its own control.

10

CHAPTER TEN

Pseudonymous Agency

Personation, Authorship, and the Responsibility Gap

10.1 The Chain of Masks

The novel is built from pseudonyms. Peter writes as Locke, Valentine as Demosthenes, Ender as the Speaker for the Dead. "Ender" is itself a mask. On the first page the adults address the boy as Andrew while the narration calls him Ender; on the last he travels the worlds as Andrew Wiggin, a wandering speaker for the dead, while the narration still calls him Ender (chs. 1, 15). Between those pages the name becomes public property: watching Graff's trial, Ender grasps that he is more useful to the world as a name and a story than as a living person (ch. 15). The game is the pseudonym of the war; Mazer is the pseudonym of the enemy, the persona behind which the queens act in the simulator (Chapter 5); "bugger" is the only name the novel gives a species that later volumes will call Formic. The apparatus counterfeits masks as readily as it wears them: when Valentine resists writing on its terms, Graff offers to write her letter himself, matching her style from the letters it intercepted (ch. 9). Each mask performs the same operation. It disarticulates an act from its agent and enables acts the agent could not perform under his own name: children cannot address the politics of the world, a child cannot destroy a species, the destroyer cannot speak for the destroyed. Under masks, each becomes possible. This chapter argues that pseudonymity is the novel's master technology, the formal correlate of everything the preceding chapters anatomized, and that its theory is to be found in Hobbes.

10.2 Hobbes: Authors, Actors, and the Reversal of Authorization

The sixteenth chapter of *Leviathan* (1651), "Of Persons, Authors, and Things Personated," begins from the stage. Hobbes notes that the Latin *persona* signifies "the Disguise, or Outward Appearance of a man, counterfeited on the Stage," and sometimes more narrowly the mask itself, while the Greek *prosōpon* signifies the face. A person is one whose words or actions are considered either as his own, a natural person, or as representing those of another, an artificial person. Where one acts by another's authority, the one who acts is the actor and the one who owns the action is the author. The author is bound by what the actor does in his name, and responsibility runs to him. Hobbes draws the consequence without hesitation: when an actor bound by covenant does something against the law of nature at the author's command, "not he, but the Author breaketh the Law of Nature."

The chapter contains a clause that bears on Ender with extraordinary precision. Children, fools, and madmen who have no use of reason, Hobbes writes, may be personated by guardians or curators, but "can be no Authors (during that time) of any action done by them," except insofar as they shall, on recovering the use of reason, judge the same reasonable. The guardian authors what the child does. The child may, on coming of age, ratify or refuse it.

The clause is a complete description of the novel's moral structure. During the war Ender is a child in Hobbes's sense, without the use of reason with respect to his act, since he does not know what the act is. He is personated by his guardians, the IF, who are the authors of everything he does in the simulator. By Hobbes's logic the xenocide is theirs, and through them humanity's, since the IF acts by the Hegemony's authority. Then comes the anagnorisis, which is precisely the recovery of the use of reason with respect to the act, and at that moment the Hobbesian clause opens: the child may now judge the action done in his name. Ender's response is neither ratification nor repudiation in the ordinary sense. He assumes authorship. He writes *The Hive Queen*, tells Valentine in his own voice that it was he who stole the enemy's future (ch. 15), and takes the deed as his own.

The true author does the opposite. Humanity, having authorized the war, disowns it once its nature is known and attributes it to the actor: inside the novel through the trial that attacks him by proxy and the exile that turns him into a name and a story, and in the sequel through the infamy of that name. Hobbesian responsibility, which runs from actor to author, is made to run backward, from author to actor. I call this *reversed authorization*: the juridical core of pharmakotic sovereignty, by which an apparatus obtains a performance from an actor who does not know he is acting, owns the result while it is useful, and disowns it once it is known, transferring its authorship to the actor. The fourth and fifth operations of Chapter

9, disclamation and transference, are reversed authorization seen from the side of the polity. Ender's assumption of authorship is the same event seen from the side of the actor, and it is the novel's ethical center. In it agency returns to the one whose agency was taken, in the only form still available: the freedom to own what he did not author.

10.3 Arendt: The Rule of Nobody and the Storyteller

Hannah Arendt's *Eichmann in Jerusalem* (1963) diagnosed in its subject not monstrous intention but thoughtlessness, an inability to think from the standpoint of anyone else, and rejected the defense that a functionary is a mere cog. In *On Violence* (1970) she described bureaucracy as the rule of Nobody, potentially the most tyrannical form of rule because no one is left who can be held to account. The IF's xenocide is the rule of Nobody perfected. The Strategos, the Polemarch, the Hegemon, Graff, Mazer, the pilots, and the child can each point elsewhere. Graff's court-martial is the forensic test of the arrangement, and its acquittal is the system's certification of Nobody's rule. Graff himself says that he knew he would be acquitted, and credits the full videos of the two deaths, which his defense showed unedited, with saving him (ch. 15). The proceedings try the recruiter for mistreatment of children and negligent homicide, attack the child by proxy, and leave the xenocide unindicted. Ender inverts Eichmann term for term. Eichmann was thoughtless and knew what he did; Ender was the most thoughtful being in his world and did not know.

Arendt's *The Human Condition* (1958) supplies the complementary insight. Action discloses who the agent is, but this "who" appears to others and remains hidden from the agent himself; the full meaning of an action becomes visible only to the storyteller, after the action is over and often after its actors are dead. Arendt took as the epigraph of her chapter on action Isak Dinesen's conviction that any sorrow can be borne once it is put into a story. The Speaker for the Dead is Arendt's storyteller institutionalized: the one who narrates, after death, who a life's agent was. Ender, whose own "who" was hidden from him in his decisive act, can come to know it only by narrating others.

Shakespeare staged the question on the eve of Agincourt. The soldier Williams tells the disguised king that if the cause is not good, the king himself will have "a heavy reckoning to make" for every limb lopped off in battle; Henry answers that each soldier's soul is his own (*Henry V*, IV.1). The scene apportions responsibility for war between sovereign and soldier, and it does so between a king in disguise and a soldier who does not know to whom he speaks. Ender is both at once: the sovereign who decides and the soldier who obeys, with a mask between them. The

novel even grants him a sovereign's rank: made an admiral after the war, he asserts its privilege only once, to watch the trial of the man who made him (ch. 15).

10.4 The Author Function and the Wiggin Children

Roland Barthes's "The Death of the Author" (1967) proposed that a text is a tissue of quotations whose unity lies in its destination, the reader, rather than its origin. Michel Foucault's "What Is an Author?" (1969) answered that the author is a function of discourse, a principle of attribution and appropriation that arose historically when discourses became transgressive and their makers could therefore be punished. Pseudonymity is the art of directing the author function. Locke and Demosthenes can transgress, as children shaping the politics of the world, because no author can be punished, and the IF, having discovered who they are, allows them to continue. The pseudonyms later negotiate Ender's fate between them: Graff hints that Demosthenes persuaded Locke, and it is Locke who argues in public for the exile that Peter had privately hoped to avoid (ch. 15). *The Hive Queen* appears under a title, not a name, an author function without a punishable author, and within the novel the mask holds: no one knows or wishes to know who the first Speaker was (ch. 15). Only the brother pierces it. When Valentine appends the book, unattributed, to her history, the aged Hegemon replies that he knows who wrote it, and that one who could speak for the enemy could surely speak for him (ch. 15). The xenocide was authorless; the book that narrates it is authorless; the name between them, in the sequel, bears both.

10.5 The Responsibility Gap: Child Soldiers and Autonomous Systems

International criminal law encodes the novel's distribution of culpability with startling fidelity. The Rome Statute of the International Criminal Court (1998) makes it a war crime to conscript or enlist children under fifteen or to use them to participate actively in hostilities (art. 8), and it denies the Court jurisdiction over anyone under eighteen at the time of the alleged crime (art. 26). The Court's first judgment (2012) convicted Thomas Lubanga Dyilo, leader of the Union of Congolese Patriots, of conscripting and enlisting children under fifteen and using them to participate actively in hostilities in the Ituri region of the Democratic Republic of the Congo in 2002 and 2003; he was sentenced to fourteen years' imprisonment. The architecture is the novel's: the child stands outside jurisdiction, and the recruiter is the criminal. Graff's recruitment of a six-year-old for active hostilities falls squarely within article 8. Roméo Dallaire's *They Fight Like Soldiers, They Die Like Children* (2010) gives the phenomenon its human face, and its title could stand as the epigraph to Ender's career.

The philosophy of autonomous weapons has reached the same structure from another direction. Andreas Matthias identified a responsibility gap opened by learning machines, whose behavior neither their makers nor their operators can fully predict or control ("The Responsibility Gap," 2004). Robert Sparrow argued that autonomous weapons open such a gap in war, since neither programmer, commander, nor machine can appropriately bear responsibility for their killings, and he drew the comparison with the child soldier ("Killer Robots," 2007). Ender is the literary prototype of that comparison. The theory of pharmakotic sovereignty adds a warning the gap literature has not always made explicit: the gap need not be an accident to be regretted; it can be a product to be designed. The IF did not stumble into Ender's innocence. It built it, because an innocent instrument is a more effective one and a more convenient bearer of guilt. Any apparatus that benefits from a responsibility gap will be tempted to engineer one.

The novel bears, finally, on a problem in the evaluation of artificial agents. Such evaluation must reckon with whether an agent can tell a test from deployment, and with what follows if its behavior depends on the distinction. The Battle School exploited the indistinguishability as a feature: its agent performed most decisively when he believed himself under examination. Long before the problem had a technical vocabulary, the novel posed the question whether an apparatus may legitimately present the real as a test in order to secure an agent's performance. Its answer is that the price is paid afterward, by the agent, as a guilt the apparatus disowns.

10.6 Reception as Ritual: The Author's Name

The reception history converges with the novel's theory, and it requires a precise record. In a 1990 essay in the Mormon magazine *Sunstone*, "The Hypocrites of Homosexuality," Card argued that laws against homosexual acts should remain on the books, to be enforced when necessary to signal that those who flagrantly broke society's sexual rules could not remain acceptable, equal citizens; he has since said that he no longer advocates criminal penalties (Windy City Times). In columns for the Greensboro *Rhinoceros Times* he wrote that many gay people had first entered homosexual life through seduction, rape, molestation, or abuse (2004), and described same-sex attraction as a reproductive dysfunction (2012) (Hines; PinkNews). In a 2008 essay for the *Mormon Times* section of the *Deseret News*, he called the judges who had legalized same-sex marriage in California dictators, and asked how long it would be before married people answered them by declaring any government that redefined marriage their mortal enemy, to be brought down and replaced (*Dialogue*; PFAW). In 2009 he joined the board of the National Organization for Marriage, which campaigned against same-sex marriage. In March 2013 the artist Chris Sprouse withdrew from a Superman story Card had co-written for DC Comics (PinkNews).

As the film approached release, Geeks OUT, a New York-based LGBT fan organization, launched a campaign called Skip Ender's Game, asking audiences not to buy tickets, discs, or on-demand rentals (LGBTQ Nation). Card answered through *Entertainment Weekly* that the novel, set more than a century in the future, had nothing to do with political issues that did not exist when it was written, that the Supreme Court's ruling had made the marriage question moot, and that he hoped the victors would show tolerance (Hollywood Reporter). Lionsgate, the film's studio, replied that it did not share his views or those of the National Organization for Marriage, that those views were irrelevant to a book and a film that did not reflect them, and that it would host a benefit premiere for LGBT causes (ibid.). Geeks OUT answered that the campaign had never been about the content of the novel or the film, but about the money already paid to Card and the millions he and the National Organization for Marriage stood to gain (PinkNews). The film's lead, Asa Butterfield, put the opposing view in a sentence: "You can't blame a work for its author" (LGBTQ Nation).

This study takes no side in that dispute, but it observes its structure. The request to separate the work from its author is a request for pseudonymous agency: to let the book act under a name that is not its maker's. The refusal is a demand that authorship be owned. The novel anticipates both positions and adjudicates neither. It shows that the separation of deed from doer is the operation by which

apparatuses absolve themselves, and it shows that the ownership of a deed by its doer is the only path to atonement. Its readers are thereby placed in Ender's position, obliged to decide how to own an act (reading, buying, admiring, teaching) whose meaning depends on facts that lie outside the act itself. The novel's theory of authorship is enacted, once again, in the history of its own reception.

The precise record sharpens the structure. Both sides of the 2013 dispute agreed that the novel's content was not at issue: the studio said the book did not reflect its author's views, and the boycott's organizers said their campaign had never been about the book. What divided them was the description under which a purchase should be judged. Under one description, buying a ticket is watching a film; under another, it is paying an author who had argued for keeping homosexual acts criminal and had campaigned against same-sex marriage, and, the organizers argued, the cause he served. The dispute is Anscombe's problem of intention under a description (Chapter 5), posed to every reader. The novel's own ethic does not settle whether to buy. It requires only that an act be owned under every description it bears, including those the actor did not choose.

10.7 Synthesis

Pseudonymous agency, Hobbesian personation reversed, Arendt's rule of Nobody and her storyteller, and the author function together constitute the juridical and narrative grammar of pharmakotic sovereignty. Against that grammar stands a single counter-move: the actor's assumption of authorship, by which he refuses the disclamation that would have spared both him and the apparatus. The assumption of authorship is not yet atonement. It is the condition of atonement, which the novel locates in a practice of testimony. To that practice the final chapter turns.

11

CHAPTER ELEVEN

The Speaker's Covenant

Testimony, Reparation, and the Redemption of the Dead

11.1 The Coda

After the war Ender is kept from Earth, and his plea to come home is censored from the broadcasts (ch. 15). The League War ends in a truce on the terms of the Locke Proposal, and Peter rises toward the hegemony he will hold. Graff, acquitted, becomes Minister of Colonization, and the colonists bound for the emptied worlds worship Ender, who cannot bear it. He agrees to sail as governor of the first colony, with Mazer as pilot and Valentine beside him, because, he says, he knows the enemy better than anyone alive (ch. 15). On the colony world he finds the scenery of the Fantasy Game built into the landscape: the Giant's corpse, the playground, the tower at the End of the World. The queens had found him through the ansible, dwelt in his dreams during the weeks he spent destroying them, learned that he did not know he was killing them, and in the time left to them built the place from his images, an imitation made by a people who had never made art (ch. 15). Behind the mirror in which he once saw Peter's face lies the pupal queen. She asks to be woken; he refuses, because humanity would only kill her people again; she shows him their grief, and he writes their story in her voice, signing it with a title rather than a name. On Earth the book becomes one religion among many; in the colonies, whose settlers live in the queens' tunnels and harvest their fields, it becomes the only one, and no colony lacks its Speaker for the Dead (ch. 15). Years later Peter, seventy-seven and failing, recognizes the hand and asks to be spoken for; Ender writes *The Hegemon*, and the two books become scripture. Ender departs with Valentine and the pupa, traveling from world to world in search of a place where she may safely wake (ch. 15).

11.2 The Speaker Against the Funeral Oration

The Western archetype of speech for the dead is Pericles' funeral oration (Thucydides 2.35–46), and the Speaker is its negation. Pericles speaks for the city. The dead are praised as instances of Athenian excellence, their individual lives absorbed into the polis's image of itself, and Pericles states plainly that valor in war should be set first, since it blots out whatever private faults the fallen had (2.42). The Speaker speaks for the dead. He tells the truth of each life, faults included, for the sake of the one who lived it rather than the community that survives. The novel's own description of the practice is exact: the Speaker says what the dead would have said, with full candor, concealing no faults and inventing no virtues, and those who attend often find the services hard to bear (ch. 15). The Periclean oration is ideology; the Speaker's is testimony.

The Hegemon tests the ethic at its hardest point. Peter is the Cain of the novel, the boy who flayed a squirrel and promised his brother death, and he is also the statesman who unified the world. Peter pours out across the ansible the story of his cruelties and his benefactions alike, and the Speaker tells both truths (ch. 15). The practice thus refuses both the hagiography of the polis and the demonization of the enemy, and it extends to the human perpetrator the same truthful attention it extended to the alien victim. That symmetry is the measure of its seriousness.

11.3 Reparation and the Depressive Position

Melanie Klein understood reparation (*Wiedergutmachung*) as the impulse, born of the depressive position, to restore the loved object that one's own aggression has damaged (Chapter 6). Ender's later life is reparation in two registers. Symbolically, he restores the Formics through narrative, giving their life a form that survives their death. Concretely, he carries the last queen across worlds in search of a home, so that the destroyed object may literally be made whole. The coda is the depressive position worked through: guilt converted not into self-punishment, which would merely continue the violence against a new object, but into care.

11.4 The Angel of History

In the ninth of his theses "On the Concept of History" (1940), Walter Benjamin reads Paul Klee's *Angelus Novus* as the angel of history. Its face is turned toward the past, where it sees a single catastrophe heaping wreckage upon wreckage; it would like to stay, awaken the dead, and make whole what has been smashed; but a storm blowing from Paradise, the storm we call progress, drives it irresistibly into the future to which its back is turned. Ender after the war is the Angelus Novus made literal by physics. Relativistic travel carries him across centuries of objective time while his face remains turned toward the dead he has made. The storm of humanity's expansion into the emptied worlds drives him forward; his work faces backward.

Benjamin's sixth thesis held that only the historian convinced that even the dead will not be safe from the enemy, if the enemy wins, has the gift of fanning the spark of hope in the past. The Speaker is that historian, with a twist Benjamin did not imagine: here the historian of the defeated is their conqueror. Benjamin's seventh thesis declares that no document of civilization is not at the same time a document of barbarism. *The Hive Queen* is the rare case of a document of barbarism written, against his own victory, by the barbarian himself.

11.5 Truth Without Amnesty

The late twentieth century's great institutional experiment in testimony was South Africa's Truth and Reconciliation Commission, established in 1995, which offered amnesty in exchange for full disclosure of politically motivated crimes. Desmond Tutu's account of its work, *No Future Without Forgiveness* (1999), defended the exchange as the price of a shared future. The Speaker's covenant resembles the commission and differs from it decisively. It demands full disclosure, but it offers no amnesty; no institution can absolve Ender, and none tries. The only forgiveness available comes from the victim, and it is offered in the victim's own voice: the book Ender writes for the queen declares that her people did not mean to harm humanity and that they forgive humanity for their death (ch. 15). The gesture exceeds even that. At the first battle the queen had expected no forgiveness from humanity; at the end she entrusts the future of her people to the one who destroyed them.

Jacques Derrida argued in "On Forgiveness" (2001) that forgiveness, if it exists, forgives only the unforgivable, and that it is corrupted whenever it is made to serve an end such as reconciliation, mourning, or national unity. The queen's entrustment is forgiveness in Derrida's sense: unconditioned, uneconomic, directed at the unforgivable. Paul Ricoeur's *Memory, History, Forgetting* (2000) closed with an epilogue on difficult forgiveness and grounded the duty of memory in a debt to the

dead. The Speaker's covenant joins Derrida's gift to Ricoeur's debt. The dead give what cannot be earned; the living owe what cannot be repaid; truth-telling is the form in which the debt is honored without pretending it can be discharged.

11.6 The Welding Link

Chapter 2 traced the Latter-day Saint doctrine that the living and the dead are perfected together, and Joseph Smith's call for a "welding link" between the generations (D&C 128:18). The Speaker's practice is a secular sealing ordinance. It binds the living to the dead by truthful narration, so that the dead are judged truly and the living are judged by the dead. The pupal queen, carried in search of a world, is the dead awaiting resurrection, and the Speaker is her vicarious officiant. Card's theological imagination, which in the body of the novel underwrote the apparatus of consecration and non-accountability, here underwrites its undoing.

The book's closing lines make the link explicit. The queen's voice imagines the kiss that might have made each species human in the other's eyes and records that instead they killed each other. It then welcomes the colonists as guest-friends, invites them into the queens' tunnels and fields, calls them the queens' hands for the work the queens can no longer do, and blesses them as adopted daughters who have come home (ch. 15). The Greek for guest-friend is *xenos*, the same word that names the stranger. Xenocide, the killing of the stranger, is answered in the dead stranger's voice by *xenia*, the sacred bond of guest-friendship. The cosmopolitan right of hospitality that neither species extended in life (Chapter 3) is extended by the dead to their killers, and the adoption completes the welding link: the living are sealed to the dead as their children.

11.7 Counter-Pharmacy

Testimony, the sixth operation of pharmakotic sovereignty, is the point at which the apparatus loses control of itself. The polity requires a moral narrative of its crime, and it receives one; but the narrative it receives indicts the polity as well as the instrument. *The Hive Queen* does not merely mourn the dead. It transforms humanity's understanding of what humanity did. Within the novel it passes from hand to hand until it seems that everyone on Earth has read it, and in the colonies, built in the tunnels of the dead, it becomes the only religion (ch. 15). The conquerors live in the houses of the conquered and keep the testimony of the conquered as their creed; in the sequels the Speaker's office acquires recognized standing across the human worlds. I call this excess *counter-pharmacy*: the remedy produced by the poison, which turns against the pharmacy that compounded it.

The scapegoat of Leviticus is sent into the wilderness and never heard from again. The scapegoat of *Ender's Game* comes back as a voice. That return is the novel's critical and hopeful remainder. An apparatus that required a scapegoat produced a witness, and the witness speaks, for the dead and against the living, in a register no sovereign authored.



Conclusion

The Engineered Innocent and the Future of Responsibility

For four decades the critical conversation about *Ender's Game* has been a trial. The prosecution, from Radford to Kessel, has charged the novel with absolving a genocidaire; the defense, led by the author, has pleaded the defendant's innocence. This dissertation has argued that the trial is misconceived, not because its questions are trivial but because its forensic form reproduces the very apparatus the novel anatomizes. The novel's subject is not the guilt or innocence of a child. It is the machinery by which a polity produces an innocent, acts through him, disowns the act, transfers its guilt, and receives back from him the narrative of its crime. I have called that machinery pharmakotic sovereignty.

Part I showed that the machinery is assembled from old parts. Plato supplied the guardian and the noble lie, which the novel tells in reverse: the dream was the earth. Rousseau supplied the captive will, freedom staged so that spontaneity serves a plan, and the Cold War supplied the strategic child. Card's own theological tradition supplied foreordination, the economy of ignorant sin, an atonement understood as knowledge according to the flesh, and the redemption of the dead. It also supplied the standard by which the novel's victory is a scandal: the plan that saves everyone by taking one person's agency is, in Card's cosmology, the plan that lost the War in Heaven. The theory of enmity from Heraclitus to Schmitt supplied the absolute enemy and the conservation of enmity; Kant supplied the peace of the graveyard; the Gita supplied the innocent instrument, whom the novel absolves by concealment rather than revelation. The comparative field showed that among the instruments of speculative fiction, only Ender's ignorance is the condition of his act's success, and only Ender returns to minister to the dead.

Part II specified the working parts. The inverted cave conceals the real as appearance and produces innocence as an engineered state, governed by the Wiggin theorem: where victory requires an empathy that would forbid the act, the act requires ignorance. The Wiggin circuit converts comprehension into a targeting faculty and returns it, after the war, to the service of the dead. Mereological misrecognition, the failure to locate the unit of mind, is the war's true cause, and the literal-

ization of the vermin metaphor subtracts the alibi on which historical genocides have depended. Harvested transgression converts each refusal into compliance, so that the spoilsport's last gesture is the game's consummation.

Part III assembled the theory. The pharmakon is named in the text as the Little Doctor; the pharmakos is Ender, the goat of the Levitical rite who is also its priest, the self-scapegoating scapegoat made possible by a pseudonym. Greek pollution law, Sophocles' Oedipus, and Bernard Williams's agent-regret supplied the category the forensic debate lacked: the killer who is innocent and yet polluted, whose fitting response is the assumption of a burden. Hobbes's theory of personation, with its clause on the child who can be no author of acts done in his name until he recovers the use of reason, supplied the juridical form of the anagnorisis; its reversal, in which responsibility flows back from author to actor, supplied the juridical form of the scapegoating. The Speaker's covenant completed the cycle and exceeded it, instituting a practice of truth without amnesty that indicts the polity it was meant to console.

Read closely, the novel states each of these structures in its own voice. Graff states the Wiggin theorem when Ender accuses him of trickery. Ender states the deed without a defendant as he watches two deaths tried and ten billion ignored. The administrators state the doctrine of harvested transgression before Ender has fought a battle, and the queen's book answers xenocide with guest-friendship. The theory proposed here does not impose a pattern on the novel. It assembles the novel's own statements into the system they imply.

The stakes of the argument are not confined to a novel. The engineered innocent is not a fantasy; it is a design pattern. It appears wherever a decision of grave consequence is executed through an agent whose knowledge of the act has been narrowed by design: in the remote operator whose interface is shared by training and combat; in the child soldier, whose recruiter the law rightly treats as the criminal; in autonomous systems whose responsibility gaps may be designed rather than discovered; and in the evaluation of artificial agents, which must decide whether the real may be presented as a test. In each case the novel's warning applies. An apparatus that benefits from innocence will be tempted to manufacture it, and the guilt it disowns does not disappear. It lands on whoever is least able to refuse it.

The novel's answer to manufactured innocence is not counter-innocence but assumed responsibility: the free ownership of what one did not author, and testimony on behalf of those whom one's innocence destroyed. Its most famous maxim taught that orientation is a decision, that one chooses which way is down. Its last chapter teaches the corresponding ethical truth. One chooses, too, which deeds are one's

own; and it is in that choice, made by the one who had every excuse to refuse it, that the possibility of atonement begins.



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Orson Scott Card · *Ender's Game* · science fiction studies · speculative fiction · political theology · pharmakotic sovereignty · pharmakon · pharmakos · scapegoat · manufactured innocence · pseudonymous agency · reversed authorization · xenocide · just war theory · supreme emergency · moral luck · agent-regret · miasma · Latter-day Saint theology · foreordination · Thomas Hobbes · Carl Schmitt · René Girard · Jacques Derrida · Hannah Arendt · mereological misrecognition · hive mind · xenology · ludology · harvested transgression · inverted cave · simulation · empathy · hermeneutics · biopolitics · child soldiers · responsibility gap · autonomous weapons · testimony · Speaker for the Dead